DRIFTHEART

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Based on, Starfinder

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FADE IN:

EXT. THE DRIFT - TEMPLE OF ALLUVION - 321 AG

A vast emptiness.

Light fractures ripple outward, each wave bending the black sea of matter beneath. Tides of psionic wind echo like silent storms.

SIX FIGURES — ALLUVION CLERICS known as DRIFTWALKERS — float in formation, cloaked in flickering robes caught between time streams.

They encircle a RAW SINGULARITY, its gravitational core pulsing with unnatural rhythm, a heart too slow, then too fast.

Hands rise. Movements slow. Deliberate.

They weave invisible threads into spacetime.

A CRYSTALLINE KEYSTONE begins to form, forged from harmonic light, silent frequency, and memory. A DRIFTHEART SHARD. The air around it bends; sound drops to nothing.

ARCHIVIST (V.O.)
In the age of the Drift crash, when Triune fell silent and the Drift fractured, six driftwalkers rose from Alluvion.
(beat)
Above a city adrift on stone and stars, they spun memory into light.
(beat)
Not to repair what was lost… but to prepare for its next breaking.
(beat)
Three shards. One for the past. One for the now. One for the still-to-come. Sent across the Drift, anchored in myth. Waiting.
(beat)
For a hand bold enough to shape the Drift again. For a choice to be made.

The YOUNGEST, a KASATHAN ARCHIVIST, steps forward. His eyes shimmer. He presses his palms into the forming shard.

A PSIONIC SURGE ripples outward, light fractures space around them, each wave cracking into brief, blinding glimpses of three distant worlds.

— A massive forest planet, storm-wreathed and wild. — A derelict Driftmoon, half-consumed by entropy. — A small planet crowned by a gleaming orbital station, ECHOHEART.

The shard SPLITS into three points of light.

For the space between heartbeats, the universe changes course.

Each shard streaks into a separate rift — vanishing across the Drift.

The Driftwalkers lower their hands. The singularity flutters like a dying flame.

ARCHIVIST (V.O.)
What survives are echos...dreams looking for anchors.

The last shimmer of the shards fades into the void.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. SKY-VILLA - NYORI PALISADES - ABASALOM STATION - EVENING

(Far from the stars... closer to home.)

The stars outside glisten like cold diamonds. A domed skyline curves over a sea of luxury towers, pinnacles of power suspended high above the rest of the station. Serenity sold by the acre.

A crystalline vista window reflects the interior of an opulent penthouse. Beyond it, endless black.

INT. SKY-VILLA - OBSERVATION BALCONY - SAME

KATARIA DARANA (17), sharp-eyed, fire beneath the polish, leans against the balcony rail. Below her, nothing. A thousand meters of vacuum and silence.

Behind her: imported flora, auto-tuned symphonics, floating crystal light fixtures. Her mother’s necklace, elegant, old, glints at her neck.

She stares into voidspace, the faint hum of the station threading through the silence. Her breath catches.

KATARIA (V.O.)
They say the void humbles you.
(beat)
(MORE)

KATARIA (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It never did. It just reminded me how far away I was from everything real.
(beat)
That no matter how bright the lights...
(beat)
...I was always falling. Just slow enough not to notice.

Her fingers tighten on the railing.

A micro-tremor from the hull shivers beneath her feet. She steps back.

KATARIA (V.O.)
I used to dream it would crack. Just once. Open wide and pull this whole place in.
(beat)
Turns out... that dream had better aim than I did.

EXT. SKY-VILLA - NYORI PALISADES - EVENING

A skytower holobillboard blazes across the pristine skyline.

ADAR-GENIC VOICE (V.O.)
At Adarcorp, we build tomorrow.

Footage plays —

- Smiling families.

- Drones planting synthetic crops.

- Spacewalkers threading solar nets.

ADAR-GENIC VOICE (V.O.)
Stability. Expansion. Unity.

Brief static. A TEEN slaps a sticker at the billboard base — ADARCORP LIES. No one stops him.

CUT TO:

INT. SKY-VILLA - FAMILY HALL - LATER

Kataria steps in from the balcony, starlight still clinging to her face. The argument is already mid-boil.

ADRIELLE DARANA (50s), pristine, matriarch of calculated charm. BRENNEN DARANA (60s), equity made flesh. They don't yell; they command.

ADRIELLE
Charity is for press cycles, Kataria. We don't rewrite the system. We use it.

KATARIA
You use it. While half the station survives on recycled nutrient sludge.

ADRIELLE
You've always been dramatic. We're not dismantling a dynasty because you watched a protest stream.

BRENNEN
(steely)
You're a Darana. That means something.

KATARIA
Then maybe I'll make it mean something else.

ADRIELLE
At your debut tonight? In your grandmother's gown? Under our name?

KATARIA
Don't worry. I won't stain the fabric.

She turns to go, her steps calm, her jaw not. A twitch in her lip betrays the spark.

BRENNEN
(as she leaves)
You'll understand when you have children. Or when you lose everything trying.

INT. SKY-VILLA - KATARIA'S ROOM - NIGHT

A plush suite, too soft, too perfect. The gold-fibered holo-silk gown floats mid-air, a trophy waiting for a victor.

Gala guest lists scroll across a holo-screen, government officials, consortium elites, corp-branded socialites. She doesn't look.

Kataria crosses to a locked drawer. Opens it.

Inside, a small silver case. And beside it, almost hidden, an encrypted comms chip, faintly pulsing.

She takes the case. Opens it. The real heirloom necklace. Platinum chain. Crimson solar opal. Enough to feed the Spike for a year.

She studies it, then smirks.

KATARIA (V.O.)
They told me it was a birthright.
(beat)
Maybe it was. But not for them.

She slips it into her jacket pocket.

A pause. Her eyes flick to the gown. Then to the stars beyond the window. Her fingers tremble, barely.

KATARIA (V.O.)
I wasn't afraid of running away.
(beat)
I was afraid of getting caught in the dark...
(beat)
...and finding out I liked it there.

She exhales. Turns. The door slides open.

CUT TO:

EXT. SPIKE SECTOR - UNDERCITY STREETS - NIGHT

Steam. Neon. Adrenaline. Noise bleeds from pipes and market hollers. KATARIA stands beside a sleek, illegal-mod HOVERBIKE that purrs with stripped-limit mods and unregistered boosters.

Her fingers brush the throttle like a familiar weapon. The echoes of her mother's voice — clipped, cold — still ring in her head. She shakes it off.

Bookies scream odds in twelve languages. MODDED RACERS rev engines. Spectators jeer from gantries and balconies.

Above, behind reinforced glass towers, ASPIS CONSORTIUM REPS sip synthwine, monitors tracking every bet. This isn't a race. It's an economy.

KATARIA (V.O.)
The higher you fly, the harder they work to make you think falling isn't real.
(smirks)
I came down here to learn how to bleed.

She pulls the Darana heirloom necklace from her pocket. Holds it just long enough for the memory to sting, then hands it to a BLACK-MARKET BOOKIE.

KATARIA
One race. That covers my buy-in.

BOOKIE
That's a rich-girl antique. Sentimental value?

KATARIA
Only to people I don't talk to anymore.

She mounts the bike. Fires it up. Blue light floods from the engine core.

Her eyes flick up to a glass-walled tower above. An ADARCORP banner flutters, smug in the artificial wind.

KATARIA (V.O.)
All that shine up top? Paid for by what they squeeze out of the rest of us.

She twists the throttle. The bike growls, hungry.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. STREET RACE CIRCUIT - MOMENTS LATER

A massive circular tunnel of forgotten infrastructure. The crowd's roar reverberates through steel and steam.

Engines scream, the race is ON.

Kataria blasts forward. Wind tears at her jacket. She weaves between freight drones, dips beneath sparking conduit, cuts hard to undercut a RACER with cybernetic boosters twitching too fast to be legal.

She nearly scrapes a wall — grit teeth — drops low to catch a dangerous shortcut duct.

A glimmer of VOIDSPACE peers through a cracked tunnel slit. Stark blackness. Stars like blades.

KATARIA (V.O.)
Voidspace always finds a way to show up.
(beat)
Guess I needed a reminder.

She guns the throttle.

FINAL CORNER — smoke, heat, chaos. Two bikes neck and neck. Kataria risks it all, pulling a micro-burst jump. Airborne — pure silence, the void yawning beneath her.

She lands. Metal screams. A flash of red, she WINS.

Cheers erupt. Flames from exhaust vents. Syndicate drones capture every angle.

EXT. PAYOUT ZONE - POST-RACE - LATER

Dim alley. Grease and neon haze. Kataria steps out, wiping her hands on a rag.

A BLACK-MARKET RUNNER slaps a digital cred-stick into her palm.

RUNNER
Lucky break.

KATARIA
No such thing.

She pockets the stick. Eyes flick toward a shadowed causeway leading deeper into the undercity. Purpose sharpens her features.

KATARIA (V.O.)
Some wins buy more than credits.

She swings back onto the bike.

Engines ignite.

She vanishes into the neon night.

CUT TO:

INT. SPIKE - SHELTER COMMONS - NIGHT

Dim lights. Steam curls from cracked vents. The air is heavy with coughs, whispers, and the slow shuffle of tired feet.

A SHELTER WORKER limps toward KATARIA. Their eyes widen when she presses the cred-stick into their trembling hands.

SHELTER WORKER
Where'd you get this much?

KATARIA
Doesn’t matter.
(beat)
Just make sure they eat.

The worker blinks fast, like they might cry. In the shadows, a SMALL CHILD watches Kataria, silent, unblinking eyes fixed like she’s a myth made real.

SHELTER WORKER
No one gives to us twice.

Kataria turns to leave. The child’s gaze follows her.

KATARIA (V.O.)
People think giving feels good.
(beat)
For me? It just made the weight shift.

She pauses in the threshold, glancing back at the room.

KATARIA (V.O.)
Legacy doesn’t come from blood. It comes from what you leave burning behind you.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. SKY-VILLA - ENTRY FOYER - LATE NIGHT

The warm marble glow of the Darana estate swells into view, replacing the shelter’s flickering neon.

Doors hiss open. Kataria strides in, jacket zipped, engine grease still smudged on her gloves.

HANDLERS stiffen. ADRIELLE and BRENNE wait at the stairs, frozen portraits of wealth and disapproval. A GALA HOST, overdressed and over-smiling, doesn’t know whether to greet her or vanish.

HANDLER
Miss Darana, guests are already inside—

KATARIA
Ten minutes.

She's already moving before the handler can protest.

INT. KATARIA'S ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The door seals. Silence.

She peels off her jacket. Pulls the heirloom necklace from her pocket — the real one — and lets her fingers brush the crimson solar opal.

A beat. Then she places it gently back into its display case.

Her eyes lift to the holo-gown suspended mid-air. Gold light shimmers across her face.

KATARIA (V.O.)
Two lives. Two roads. One leads to silk and silence.
(beat)
The other... somewhere I can breathe.

A holo-alert flashes, "WELCOME, KATARIA DARANA. YOUR GUESTS AWAIT."

She turns her back to it.

Moves to her desk. Slides open a drawer, revealing a hidden panel.

INT. SKY-VILLA - PRIVATE VAULT - CONTINUOUS

Cold light spills over neat rows of high-value credsticks and sealed assets. The hum of security systems vibrates in the air.

She enters a code. The vault sighs open.

Her hand hovers over the credsticks — takes several. Starts to close the drawer… then pauses.

Grabs one more.

KATARIA (V.O.)
I didn’t know where I was going yet.
(beat)
Only that I was done breathing their air.
(beat)
I wasn’t just leaving them.
(beat)
I was choosing everyone they refused to see.

The vault seals behind her. Lights dim in her wake.

CUT TO:

EXT. STATION DOCK - LOADING BAY - NIGHT

Luxury’s glow is gone. Now — heat from venting coolant, neon hazard strobes, the tang of grease and ozone.

An industrial labyrinth of metal and motion. Cargo droids hiss past. Dock workers shout over alarms. Migrants, merchants, and shadows all pushing forward.

KATARIA moves among them, hood up, eyes down — carrying only what she stole and what she chose to keep. Her grip on the credsticks is tight enough to whiten knuckles.

She slips aboard a beat-up freighter bound for the Diaspora. No questions asked.

INT. FREIGHTER - PASSENGER HOLD - LATER

Dim lights. Scuffed benches. The low whine of deep-space prep. The air smells like stale ration packs and ion grease.

Kataria sits alone, face half-lit by a flickering panel. She’s still, but her eyes track every shadow.

A voice cuts through the hum —

NAVASI (20s) leans against a bulkhead. Purple hair. Blue supergiant eyes. Tattoos like star maps. Calm chaos in worn leather.

NAVASI
You don’t move like a tourist.

KATARIA
You don’t move like you care.

NAVASI
I don’t. Unless you’re planning to cost me.

Their eyes lock. Not flirtation — recognition. Two storms catching the same wind.

MONTAGE —
— Kataria trailing Navasi through the freighter’s warren of corridors as alarms blare; Navasi hotwires a hatch before anyone else can.

— Sharing ration bars in a stolen corner of quiet, trading half-smiles that aren’t about kindness — they’re about trust.

— Sparks flying as they fix a fried circuit board together; Kataria handing the tool before Navasi asks.

— Kataria catching sight of a tattoo on Navasi’s wrist: a stylized winged symbol — Weydan’s mark.

— FLASH MEMORY: Navasi slamming the cockpit latch, sealing Kataria inside as light flares white outside.

— Kataria, later, dyeing her hair purple, slipping in blue contacts, pulling on Navasi’s patched-up jacket.

KATARIA (V.O.)
She told me, you don’t run from injustice...
(beat)
You run straight into it.
(beat)
So I did.

She pulls the old jacket tight. A new patch stitched into the collar: NAVASI.

KATARIA (V.O.)
I took her name. But I carry her war.

A deep, low rumble of departing engines fills the hold. The galaxy opens ahead.

FADE TO:

EXT. DERELICT DRIFTMOON - ORBITAL - NIGHT

A cracked moon drifts through the Fold. Time-bent gravitational tides bend light and memory around it. Ancient Vault remnants crackle with faint psionic residue.

INT. DROPSHIP HOLD - EN ROUTE - NIGHT

Crates shake. Metal rattles. The hum of tension.

Inside: a salvage team of six. Freelancers and ex-pirates, hardened and quiet.

NAVASI — formerly Kataria Darana — (21), sharp-eyed, tempered by three years on the edge, sits alone. Her jacket bears a minor salvage crew emblem, frayed but worn with pride. The silver charm at her wrist catches the low light, the only trace of the life she left behind.

Across from her, DRAETH VORN (29), coiled precision and quiet menace, polishes a sidearm like it's ritual.

DRAETH
Didn't think you'd show.

NAVASI
You really think I'd let you walk into a cursed Vault without me?

DRAETH
Thought maybe you wised up. Found something cleaner.

NAVASI
Clean doesn't pay.
(beat)
Risk is honest.

He watches her, a flicker of something softer in his gaze. Fondness buried under calculation.

DRAETH
Still wearing that thing?

He nods toward the charm.

NAVASI
Reminder.

DRAETH
Of what?

NAVASI
Who I was.
(beat)
What I'm not going back to.

Draeth's silence lingers a fraction too long, as if measuring her against some unspoken bargain.

INT. VAULT ENTRY CHAMBER - NIGHT

The crew steps into a cathedral of ancient stone and alien tech. DRIFT GLYPHS spiral across the walls, looping endlessly.

Navasi moves forward, drawn. As she nears, the glyphs IGNITE — lines bending, curling toward her like they recognize her.

Wind stirs from nowhere. Dust lifts. Loose gear rattles. One freelancer stumbles back.

Distant whispers rise — calling names.

Draeth's hand tightens on his weapon, eyes flicking between Navasi and the living walls.

CREW MEMBER
What the hell—

DRAETH
That supposed to happen?

NAVASI
No idea.
(beat)
But it knows me.

A subtle shift in Draeth, interest sharpening into something else.

With a deep GROAN, the Vault's massive stone doors begin to open, not like a mechanism, but like a creature inviting her in.

INT. VAULT INNER SANCTUM - CONTINUOUS

They move through echoing stillness. The air hums, a low, resonant thrum, like the chamber itself is breathing.

At the center, the DRIFTHEART SHARD floats above an obsidian pedestal — humming, ancient, sentient.

Navasi steps forward. The glyphs ripple to life in a cascade of light, spiraling toward her.

DRAETH
(tense, low)
It's reacting to you. Like before.

NAVASI
(whispers)
It remembers me.

A faint psychic echo — a child's laugh, a sky split with light — flickers in her mind.

She reaches out.

DRAETH
Wait—

Too late. The shard pulses, releasing a harmonic shockwave.

VAULT:

The chamber ripples. A psionic ring of force knocks three crew members off their feet — gone, incinerated mid-scream.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Navasi—MOVE!

The Vault SHRIEKS, walls crackle with energy.

Navasi dives. Draeth yanks her down behind a half-collapsed console.

NAVASI
What did you do?

Draeth's bleeding. One leg crushed under debris.

He doesn't answer.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
What. Did. You. Do.

DRAETH
I pinged a drift signal — Corpse Fleet trace. Thought they'd intercept. Delay. Not… spike the Vault.

NAVASI
You sold the drop?

DRAETH
No — just noise. I didn't know this would happen.

NAVASI
You didn't trust me.

DRAETH
You don't get to live out here on trust.

Her eyes burn, rage, sorrow, disbelief.

The Vault begins to fracture inward, light bending like it's folding time.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
(takes her hand)
Take the shard. Before this whole place caves.

He jams the Driftheart into her grip.

NAVASI
I'm not leaving you.

DRAETH
You already did.
(beat)
That's not blame. That's why you'll survive this.

The stone floor beneath him buckles, pulling him toward the core. Just before the light swallows him, a flicker — a dark, metallic tendril in the rift.

NAVASI
Draeth!

DRAETH
Don't carry guilt. Carry meaning.

He pries her fingers from his wrist.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Forgive me, Nav—

He's gone.

INT. ESCAPE SHAFT - MOMENTS LATER

Navasi stumbles into a Drift-sled, hair soaked with sweat, face cut, eyes dead.

The Vault implodes behind her — a silent eruption of light.

INT. COCKPIT - DRIFT-SLED

The Driftheart Shard HUMS in her lap.

She pulls the silver charm from her wrist.

Stares.

Opens the hatch and hurls it into the void.

NAVASI (V.O.)
We all carry pieces of who we were.

Some cut too deep to keep.

She grips the shard tighter.

NAVASI (V.O.)
Others… show us who we're meant to become.

No tears.

Just fire.

NAVASI (V.O.)
And when the time comesâ€¦
(beat)
I choose.

She slams the drive.

The sled BLASTS into the Drift — swallowed by light.

SMASH TO BLACK:

TITLE CARD: STARFINDER — DRIFTHEART

EXT. ABSALOM STATION - SPIKE SECTOR - NIGHT

The SPIKE: a vertigo stack of industrial chasms, scaffolded sky-bridges, and neon-soaked exhaust clouds. Gravity stabilizers GROAN beneath the megastructure.

Mag-rails scream overhead, hauling ore barges. Drone traffic zigzags through heat shimmer and coolant vapor.

A STOLEN HOVERBIKE BLURS into view, slicing between freight lanes.

NAVASI (26), lean and lethal, visor cracked, hazard light glinting in her eyes. Every move is survival, sharpened over years.

She banks hard, kicking off a vertical column. PLASMA JETS bloom blue —

FLASH MEMORY:

DRAETH pinned under rubble. His voice, ragged.

DRAETH (V.O.)
Don’t carry guilt. Carry meaning.

BACK TO SCENE:

Her jaw tightens. She accelerates, fingers brushing the side pouch.

A faint HUM beneath the roar, the DRIFTHEART SHARD, sealed in its containment cylinder. It vibrates with memory.

TWO CORPORATE SECURITY DRONES dive after her, sirens wailing.

NAVASI
(into comm)
Clo, if you’re listening, now’s a great time to clear me a runway.

HUD — The bike’s display flashes red.

ILLEGAL VESSEL // FORCE TERMINATION IN PROGRESS

She slams a spike device into the console.

CLOAK GRID ENGAGED —

The bike FLICKERS, distortion bending her signal trail. The drones scramble.

INT. SPIKE VENTILATOR SHAFT - CONTINUOUS

Steam blinds. Fan blades spin like guillotines.

Navasi dives through — inches from metal teeth.

One drone clips a rotor — SHREDDING into a firestorm of sparks.

EXT. MAINTENANCE CATWALK - CONTINUOUS

She BURSTS onto a suspended walkway above a molten alloy pit. The second drone CLOSE BEHIND.

She whips the bike around and LAUNCHES OFF THE EDGE —

EXT. ORE TRAM - CONTINUOUS

The hoverbike arcs high toward a tram far below.

CLO waits across the tramway, framed in flickering industrial light, EMP GRENADE in hand.

NAVASI
(into comm)
Clo — lock and load!

She FLIPS the bike midair, thrusters SCREAMING —

CLO
Coming in hot!

SLOW MOTION:

The EMP spins. Sparks.

Navasi SNATCHES it mid-flight — powers down the bike.

The bike drops away, free-falling.

She leaps — ACTIVATING the EMP.

The drone convulses, powers down — CRASHES into the platform.

END SLOW MOTION:

Navasi SLAMS down on the tram, rolls, skids toward the molten edge.

Her hand SNAGS a steel bar. Inches from liquid fire.

NAVASI
Note to self… more subtle landings.

She hauls herself up, hair singed at the tips. Clo just stares.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Told you I'd bring back parts.

CLO
That was parts?

NAVASI
Improvisation. Core skillset.

She flicks a disrupt spike into the drone. It flares — its whole profile vanishes from scanners.

CLO
You just wiped its signature?

NAVASI
Why waste a good stealth core?

VEERA (V.O.)
Of course you stole it. And I already hate it. Cargo bay. Now.

NAVASI
Sweep it for trackers. We're not making friends today.

VEERA (V.O.)
Already done. And my IQ's still higher.

They stride into the steam.

CLO
(quiet)
Sometimes I wonder if I was the first.

NAVASI
First what?

CLO
Clone. Version. Whatever. Maybe there's another one out there… still waiting to be pulled out of the dark.

Navasi doesn't answer. Her hand brushes the shard pouch. It HUMS.

She looks ahead, eyes hard.

They vanish into the station haze.

CUT TO:

EXT. HAWKMOON GARAGE - LOWER SPIKE - NIGHT

A rusted docking bay carved between vent shafts. Neon letters flicker, HAWKMOON REPAIRS. Coolant lines HUM overhead like distant thunder.

INT. GARAGE FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

Navasi SLAMS the scorched hoverbike part onto a slab. It still smolders.

Clo heaves the broken drone carcass onto a lift table.

NAVASI
I'll take creds over credits.

CLO
We still owe on two reactor cycles. And we're out of ration chits.

VEERA (V.O.)
Correction. You owe. I'm an unpaid hostage.

NAVASI
You're a ship core with sarcasm protocols. We're lucky you're not charging us rent.

VEERA (V.O.)
I considered it. Then remembered your credit rating. Spoiler, you don't have one.

CLO
Should I remind you both we're still being pinged?

A terminal flickers. A distorted STARFINDER SIGIL pulses weakly.

NAVASI
Ghost-signal. Starfinder code fragment.

VEERA (V.O.)
From a derelict kiosk near the rim. Tier-3 data burst. Encrypted.

CLO
Could be bait.

NAVASI
Could be useful.

VEERA's console CHIRPS again. Harsher.

VEERA (V.O.)
New transmission. Marked priority. Aspis Consortium.

Navasi freezes.

CLO
That's bad, right?

VEERA (V.O.)
They're not known for friendly reminders.

Navasi crosses the floor. Slams her hand on the console. A grim icon flickers, ASPIS COLLECTION NOTICE.

NAVASI
I bought us time last quarter. We should have—

VEERA (V.O.)
Three days until enforcement protocol. Maybe less. They moved the deadline.

CLO
What kind of enforcement?

NAVASI
The kind that dismembers before negotiations.

OUTSIDE THE PULL-DOWN:

A BLACKED-OUT ASPIS OPERATIVE watches from the shadows. Ocular implants flicker faint red. A slow click of gauntlet fingers—then he melts back into the mist.

INT. GARAGE FLOOR - LATER

The chaos has cooled. Dim lights. Old conduits HUM in the walls.

Navasi sits alone at the cluttered workbench. A mug of synth-caf steams beside her. Her eyes rest on the DRIFTHEART SHARD, faintly pulsing. Between her fingers, she turns Draeth's scorched insignia. Feeling, not looking.

Clo enters quietly.

CLO
Still spinning that thing like it'll give you answers?

NAVASI
If I spin it fast enough, maybe it'll turn time backward.

CLO
And skip this part of the story.

He sits. Familiar silence between them.

CLO (CONT'D)
We're not just out of creds, Nav…
we're out of time.

NAVASI
Time's a luxury for people not
being hunted.

CLO
You think it's really the shard?

She glances at it. The shard glimmers—like it heard him.

NAVASI
It's not just tech. Older than the
Pact. Older than the Drift.

CLO
You said there were others.

NAVASI
Vault fragments spoke of three. One
to map. One to breach. One to
command.

CLO
And worth killing for.

NAVASI
Which is why someone already tried.

She tosses down the insignia.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Draeth knew. He gave up our
location five years ago to get
inside that first Vault.

CLO
You think he knew about the shard?

NAVASI
Not at first. But when it opened
for me—when I walked out and the
others didn't—he started watching
me like I was the Vault.

A heavy beat.

CLO
So where is he now?

NAVASI
Gone. Dead, maybe.

VEERA (V.O.)
No verified activity on galnet, bounty logs, or necrotic drift tags. Probability of survival: statistically null.

CLO
Good. One less ghost to chase.

VEERA (V.O.)
Unconfirmed absence is not absence. Merely… untracked presence.

NAVASI
Let's keep it that way.

She stands. Shoulders squared.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
If that kiosk has navdata, a dead pilot's log, even a drift echo—it might show us where the shard wants to go.

CLO
You sure we're ready for this?

NAVASI
No. But if we wait, someone worse opens that vault.

VEERA (V.O.)
Escape vectors plotted. Final will template uploaded. Trauma profiles updated. Shall I prep sealed gear protocols?

NAVASI
Do it.

Clo grabs his gear. Pauses at the door.

CLO
If this doesn't work—

NAVASI
It will.

CLO
And if it does?

NAVASI
Then we make sure we're the ones holding the pieces.

The shard pulses. Stronger this time. Almost eager.

She tucks it deep into her jacket.

EXT. LOWER SPIKE - TRANSIT CORRIDOR - NIGHT

The hum of VEERA'S last line from the garage scene lingers faintly in Navasi's comm as she and Clo move fast and quiet through the underbelly of the Spike.

The walls sweat condensation, pulsing faintly with power leaks. Cracked light-panels flicker overhead like broken stars. Somewhere deep in the pipes, water hammers against rust.

A sewage drone skitters past, sensors twitching.

They round a corner to a tunnel wall layered in graffiti:

"HOPE IS A SYSTEM GLITCH."

"BREATHE FREE OR NOT AT ALL."

A half-scrubbed STARFINDER EMBLEM beneath it all.

CLO
Thought the Society cleaned this stretch.

NAVASI
They stopped when patrols started vanishing.

CLO
You think it's true? Drift-wraith in the ventways, feeding on people?

NAVASI
I think people disappear.

They descend a narrow metal stairwell. Broken steps. Dripping echoes. A faint pulse from the shard in her jacket syncs with the corridor's failing lights.

CLO
You sure you remember the way?

NAVASI
I never forget dead ends.

A LOW MECHANICAL CHITTERING.

They freeze. Clo’s hand goes to his weapon.

The shadows shift. Just scavenger mechs, fighting over a dead power cell.

CLO
Friendly neighborhood clean-up crew.

They keep moving.

EXT. SPIKE MARKET WASTE CHANNEL - MOMENTS LATER

The route narrows between warped steel supports. Steam seeps from fractured pipes.

They pass a makeshift shanty hidden in a collapsed cargo duct. A child watches from behind a tattered sheet—eyes wide, shining in the dark.

Navasi stops. Reaches into her jacket, pulls a worn ration bar, and drops it gently on the floor.

The child vanishes with the food.

CLO
You don’t have to do that.

NAVASI
Can’t help what you see.

They move on. Clo glances at her, a flicker of respect he doesn’t voice.

Ahead, a FAINT BLUE PULSE cuts through the haze, throbbing in the fog beyond.

NAVASI (CONT’D)
There.

CLO
That’s the kiosk?

NAVASI
That’s the ghost trying to speak.

The pulse quickens. Clo’s HUD glitches for half a second, static crawling his display.

They push forward, vanishing into steam and shadow as the silent hum of ancient tech begins to wake.

EXT. SPIKE SECTOR - ABANDONED CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Steam coils around Clo and Navasi as they move fast but quiet. The walls hum faintly with old, half-dead energy.

Ahead, a derelict STARFINDER KIOSK, rusted, flickering, its cracked display barely holding on. Above it, half-lit:

SEEK. CHART. RETURN.

Navasi slows.

NAVASI
It's still broadcasting.

CLO
There hasn't been a clean Society signal in years.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD, hidden beneath her coat, PULSES faintly. Steam shivers in sync. The kiosk flickers harder, like it knows she's here.

VEERA (V.O.)
Unstable link. Residual drift-echo in the signal. Possible live spike.

Navasi steps forward. Fingers dance over the cracked console. A burst of corrupted static resolves into distorted coordinates overlaying a sector of uncharted Drift.

A single word bleeds onto the display in broken script.

ECHORIFT.

CLO
Never heard of it.

NAVASI
That's because it doesn't want to be found.

The console spasms — for a heartbeat, a CORPSE FLEET GLYPH burns across the screen, glitching like it's bleeding into her vision. Then gone.

Navasi freezes. Breath tightens.

A DRY LAUGH cuts the steam.

They turn, a hunched MYSTIC VAGRANT emerges half from shadow, half from a vent grille, like he's been there the whole time listening. Eyes glow faintly, not tech. Drift-touched.

MYSTIC VAGRANT
It breathes again, you know. The Vault. The sky wound. And the key's already bleeding.

CLO
(low)
Nav… you know this guy?

NAVASI
I think he knows me.

The Vagrant's fingers twitch, tracing DRIFT-GLYPHS in the air. Psionic murmurs bleed from his skin.

MYSTIC VAGRANT
(CHANTING)
One name… two shadows…

One shard awakens, the others hunger. Do you bleed forward… or backward?

The DRIFTHEART thrums harder — visible now through her coat. The steam around them trembles.

The Vagrant suddenly SHRIEKS — eyes blown wide — then collapses, convulsing.

CLO
Okay… I'm officially done with this corridor.

Navasi turns back to the kiosk. It spits out a small DATA SPIKE and a crystalline MAP NODE. She grabs them, pockets quick.

The Vagrant's voice, now a ragged whisper:

MYSTIC VAGRANT
Echoes find echoes.

The Vault sees through masks.

Navasi goes still. The shard hums, low and steady.

She straightens.

NAVASI
Load the Rough Draft. We drift at zero-six.

CLO
I thought we were laying low.

NAVASI
We are. Nobody sane takes this route.

BEHIND THEM — A LENS irises open in the wall. Then another. Different angle. Both recording.

The shard pulses once more — deeper this time — like it knows it's been seen.

CUT TO:

EXT. ORBITAL ANGLE - ABSALOM STATION - CONTINUOUS

The faint signal from the kiosk ripples into the void, a drifting pulse of blue light.

It travels, past cargo haulers and patrol skiffs, until it touches a shape in the black.

A sleek ABADARCORP CORVETTE, holding in geosync above the station. Its void-black plating absorbs starlight, swallowing reflections whole.

INT. CORVETTE - SECURED INNER CHAMBER - DEEP VOID

No lights, only BLOOD-RED pulses from embedded VOID-RUNES. The air bends inward. Pressure builds like the room itself is breathing.

The architecture defies geometry, walls curve without edges, angles that shouldn't exist holding together by dark Drift energy.

DRAETH VORN (34) enters. Older. Hardened. A ghost wearing his own skin.

At the center, A CORPSE FLEET ENFORCER hangs in suspended animation. Undead. Hooded in voidsteel threads. Bone splinters pierce cracked armor. In its chest, a glowing singularity of anti-life magic, pulsing like a diseased heart.

DRAETH
I've sent the signal.

The Enforcer does not move. But invisible pressure ripples the air. Draeth's breath clouds despite no cold.

FLASH:

His family—wife, daughter—trapped in STASIS PODS. Suspended in psychic scream-fields. Blood tears drift. Their mouths stretch wide, endlessly, but no sound escapes.

BACK:

ENFORCER (V.O. / PSIONIC)
She opens the Vault… or we open them.

Void-scorch scars slither along Draeth's neck—living runes burned into his flesh.

DRAETH
She'll go. She has to.

ENFORCER (V.O. / PSIONIC)
Faith. Fragile. Suffering…

The Enforcer's jaw CRACKS open, not to speak, but to exhale a slow coil of black SMOKE. It writhes upward like souls clawing at the ceiling.

ENFORCER (CONT'D)
…is eternal.

The pressure snaps. Draeth staggers back, spine arched in psychic recoil.

INT. CORVETTE - BRIDGE - MOMENTS LATER

Draeth steadies himself, blood and sweat streaking his face. He approaches a HOLO-RELAY ALTAR, ancient Starfinder tech, corrupted with abyssal code.

He keys the transmission. Coordinates flicker onscreen—matching the burn pattern now sealed in Navasi's data spike.

DRAETH
Only one pilot would be reckless enough to take it.

A soft ping—confirmation.

INCOMING ACCEPTANCE CONFIRMATION: NAVASI <<

DRAETH (V.O.)
Forgive me, Nav. I tried to die a better man. They wouldn't let me.

He reaches for a control.

ACTIVATE - HUNTER MINE SWARM

EXT. CORVETTE - HULL - CONTINUOUS

A vent IRISES OPEN. Inside, sleek hunter mines unfold like metallic predators waking from hibernation. Their sensor arrays flare—catching a scent.

They launch—silent, fast—vanishing into the Drift.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER SPIKE - EDGE OF THE ZONE - NIGHT

Thick steam coils upward, catching the faint orange glow of broken vent-fires. The industrial veins of Absalom Station feel alive here—grinding, hissing, breathing.

Navasi walks ahead of Clo toward the docking slips. Her steps are sharp, focused… but something flickers behind her eyes.

SOUND STRETCHES.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD, hidden in her jacket, pulses like a second heartbeat.

Her breath falters. One hand to the wall.

ANGLE ON HER EYES, they dilate unnaturally, catching light from nowhere.

WHISPERS in the dead dialect bleed through, oily and layered — the same cadence as the Vagrant's chant.

VOICE (V.O. / MULTIPLE LAYERS)
…Navasi…

FLASH:

— The Vault DOOR exploding open, ash clouds curling like screaming spirits.

— Draeth's silhouette, backlit by black DRIFTFIRE, hand reaching.

— The Corpse Enforcer's bone-hand spiraling through dimensions.

— THREE SHARDS, spinning apart in the dark.

FLASH CUT:

Navasi staggers back. Grabs the railing.

CLO (O.S.)
Nav? You good?

She exhales, forces control.

NAVASI
Let's get to the ship.

Behind her in the steam, a DRIFT-SHADOW ripples… then is gone.

CUT TO:

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - ENGINE CORE - LATER

Hissing steam. Tool clatter. Sparks spit as Navasi hangs upside-down in the Drift Drive housing, sleeves rolled, face smudged. Wires and memory wafers exposed like veins and scar tissue.

VEERA (V.O.)
Statistically speaking, twenty-one percent of jury-rigged Drift jumps end in catastrophic disintegration.

NAVASI
If I wanted a lecture, I'd have joined the academy. You're running on hacked firmware, Veera. Don't get righteous.

VEERA (V.O.)
I'm not righteous. I'm immortal.

CLO (O.S.)
This cable's scorched.

Clo holds up a frayed junction coupler.

NAVASI
It still conducts. We only need thirty seconds past death.

CLO
That's… comforting.

NAVASI
Hand me the phase stabilizer.

CLO
Broken one or brokener one?

NAVASI
Surprise me.

CUT TO:

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - COCKPIT - LATER

A patched-together fusion of Pact World tech and outlaw salvage. Panels glow unevenly. Exposed wires pulse faint Driftlight. The canopy is heat-warped, chipped.

It shouldn't fly. But it breathes. Loyal. Fast. Held together by will.

Navasi slams the ignition rune. The Rough Draft GROANS — a shudder through the deckplates like it's waking up angry.

CLO
These coordinates don't look real.

NAVASI
They're not supposed to be found.

VEERA (V.O.)
And yet you aim us straight at them.

NAVASI
Maybe I like a challenge.

VEERA (V.O.)
Psychotic confirmed.

EXT. DOCKING SLIP - NIGHT

Engines spool. Plasma coils hum.

BLASTER FIRE rains from above.

Two ASPIS AGENTS drop from a vent shaft. More flood from the shadows.

ASPIS AGENT
Breach of collections protocol—

BLAM! Navasi fires from the cockpit window. One agent spins back.

CLO
I thought we had three days!

NAVASI (O.S.)
Corporate math, Clo!

INT. BOARDING CORRIDOR - NIGHT

Clo sprints, opens portside access. Blaster bolts scorch the deck.

He hurls a FLASH CHARGE.

BOOM — white light and smoke swallow the bay.

Clo dives back up the ramp as stun-nets whirl past.

INT. COCKPIT

VEERA (V.O.)
Deploying sonic stun.

A PIERCING SHRIEK vibrates through the hull. Outside, agents clutch helmets, disoriented.

NAVASI
Veera — push start protocols!

EXT. DOCKING SLIP - CONTINUOUS

Thrusters KICK. Debris whirls. Agents scatter.

Magnetic anchors fire — one SLAMS into the hull.

INT. CARGO BAY - SAME TIME

Clo rips the tether free, tumbling back.

CLO
Got it!

INT. COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

NAVASI
Cut all tethers. Dump ballast.

VEERA (V.O.)
Aggressive ascent engaged.

EXT. DOCKING SLIP - SAME TIME

The Rough Draft BLASTS upward, smashing through crates and agents. Mag-lines SNAP.

It punches into the upper lanes — vanishing into traffic.

INT. ENGINE CORE - MOMENTS LATER

COOLANT sprays. Sparks arc.

Navasi dives into the Drift Drive bay, yanking wires.

CLO (O.S.)
That better be the right stabilizer!

NAVASI
We're about to find out!

The DRIVE SCREAMS, then steadies.

INT. COCKPIT - NIGHT

Clo drops into co-pilot. Navasi's hands blur over controls. Ships whip past outside.

CLO
Drift lock in progress!

VEERA (V.O.)
Trackers inbound. Aspis and Syndicate.

NAVASI
Blind them!

VEERA (V.O.)
Decoys away.

A FLARE BLAST rocks the ship. Panels spark.

CLO
This is a bad plan!

NAVASI
Not a plan. A lifestyle!

She dives the ship into a narrow grav-gap—

EXT. SKYWAY - NIGHT

The Rough Draft skims under haulers, vanishes between lanes.

INT. COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

The Drift vector aligns. Stars stretch.

CLO
Drift drive ready!

VEERA (V.O.)
Trajectory, unstable.

NAVASI
Punch it!

She SLAMS the rune.

EXT. ROUGH DRAFT - DRIFTSPACE

The ship LURCHES — jagged stormlight TEARS open, swallowing them.

For a breath — alarms scream, hull rattles, the viewplate fractures.

Then-

SILENCE.

Only the echo of what they left behind.

CUT TO:

EXT. ORBITAL ANGLE - ABSALOM STATION - CONTINUOUS

The obsidian ABADARCORP CORVETTE hangs above the station like a phantom, perfectly still. Its hull swallows starlight, reflecting nothing back.

INT. CORVETTE - STRATEGY CHAMBER - DRIFTSPACE

Darkness pulses with psionic static. A dim glow spills from a holo-map — a cluster of coordinates burning faintly, ECHORIFT among them.

Draeth stands in silence hollow-eyed. Black runes spidering up his neck have spread, branching across his jaw and collarbone. They pulse faintly with driftfire, as if feeding on him.

FLASH:

— His wife and daughter, still trapped in psychic stasis. But the field is unstable now, glitching. Their features fracture into jagged shards of static.

— Their mouths still locked in silent screams, but their eyes dart wildly now aware, pleading.

— Threads of blood tear drift upward, warping in slow motion then vanish as the vision stutters.

BACK:

He exhales, slow, controlled, over a fracture of rage.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
She bears the key. The Vault will awaken.

DRAETH
Not yet. She has to open it — willingly.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
The corporations grow… restless. You swore a blood-oath, Draeth. The Drift remembers.

A shadow coalesces behind him. The ENFORCER manifests fully, towering, spectral, death incarnate. Armor slick with neural rot. Face like cracked glass.

ENFORCER
You were marked. Yours is not a vow — it is a bond.

DRAETH
You promised she'd be spared.

ENFORCER
We promised nothing. We simply… allowed you to hope.

DRAETH
If we kill her, how do you expect to find the last shard?

The Enforcer leans closer. The light around Draeth dims.

ENFORCER
The Vaults are echoes. The first two will sing to the third. With or without her.

DRAETH
But she’s the only one who’s opened one.

ENFORCER
Then let her open this one. And if she resists, end her.

The holo-map updates. A digital flicker — THE ROUGH DRAFT — damaged, escaping pursuit.

Draeth watches grainy footage of the ship hurtling through debris and shattered Aspis drones.

DRAETH
Aspis made contact. But she got out.

ENFORCER
As expected.

DRAETH
Set a drift-lock on her vector. Prepare jump alignment.

ENFORCER
The Vault awaits. And your debt… remains unpaid.

DRAETH
I know.

He presses a bloodied thumb to the console — part oath, part command.

DRAETH (V.O.)
They wouldn’t let me die. Not until I deliver her.

The ship vibrates. Coordinates lock.

EXT. CORVETTE - CONTINUOUS

The Drift tears open like a wound. The corvette slides in after the ROUGH DRAFT.

INT. ARMORY - MOMENTS LATER

Draeth opens a relic case. The soul-forged blade rests inside — heavy, dim.

He grips it.

DRAETH (V.O.)
I was supposed to protect her. But blood has rules.

He sheathes it, gaze fixed, jaw locked.

DRAETH (V.O.)
And this time I won't be the one who gets to choose.

CUT TO:

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - OBSERVATION NOOK - DRIFTSPACE

Quiet.

Stormlight from the Drift swirls beyond the warped viewport, unreal, suspended in a gravity that isn't gravity at all.

NAVASI sits curled on a battered bench. Jacket half-unzipped. Face shadowed. Present, but with edges frayed.

She pulls out the DRIFTHEART SHARD, holds it loose in her palm. It pulses, faint and deliberate, like it knows she's watching.

A faint residue of vibration hums through the hull, the same drift-tone that just locked onto their vector in Draeth's chamber.

CLO (O.S.)
You always come here after a jump.

She doesn't look back. Just nods.

NAVASI
Easier to breathe when the stars stop pretending to go somewhere.

Clo steps in. Two mugs of synth-brew. One chipped. One still warm.

He hands her the warm one.

CLO
You saw something in the Drift.

She sips. Then-

NAVASI
I always do.

CLO
This time was worse.
(beat)
You called out. But you didn’t say my name.

She stays still.

NAVASI
It wasn’t you I was afraid of losing.

CLO
Then who?

She meets his eyes, a flicker of something unguarded.

NAVASI
The version of me that still believed this had an end.

CLO
End of what?

NAVASI
Running. Fighting. Chasing ghosts.
(beat)
Thought there’d be a vault, or a kill-switch, or some last job that made it all stop.
(beat)
Turns out… it’s just the shape of who I am now.

He sits, not too close, but close enough that the gravity between them is felt.

CLO
You think the shard’s part of you?

NAVASI
I think it sees things I’m not ready to admit.
(beat)
But it doesn’t lie.
(MORE)

NAVASI (CONT'D)
That's more than I can say for most people I've followed.

CLO
Including me?

NAVASI
No.
(beat)
You never lied.
(beat)
You just haven't chosen who you want to be yet.

Silence. The shard's light dims, then swells — a slow, knowing pulse.

CLO
I used to think I was a copy of a better version.

NAVASI
And now?

CLO
Now I think maybe the original didn't survive. And I'm what's left.
(beat)
Still scared that's not enough.

NAVASI
It is.
(beat)
But being enough doesn't mean it won't still hurt.

The shard warms against her palm, soft, but certain.

They sit there. Not healed. Not whole. But not drifting alone.

The shard pulses once more, sharper now — like a signal.

Navasi looks to Clo.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Then let's see where it wants to take us.

CUT TO:

EXT. DRIFTSPACE - THE VOID BETWEEN - LATER

The ROUGH DRAFT drifts through the starless dark, its hull battered, lights dim, engines pulsing in cautious rhythm. Here, the stars don't move. They hover like scars in glass, frozen and watchful.

This is the VOID BETWEEN, the unstable corridor between Drift lanes. Space bends. Scale warps. Geometry breathes.

In the ship's wake, a shimmer glitches once—then stabilizes. A sleek HUNTER MINE peels from the dark, phase-ghosted, invisible to sensors. No heat. No propulsion. Only intent. It follows, unblinking.

EXT. THE DRIFT - ECHORIFT APPROACH

A violent pulse of Driftlight and the ROUGH DRAFT breaks through into an anomaly field where the void feels alive.

Violet stormlight coils in tendrils, brushing the hull like curious fingers. Lightning fractals hang mid-bolt, frozen. Time itself seems to hesitate.

Ahead, a silhouette emerges. The ECHORIFT.

A broken horizon curled inward, ringed in gravitational bloom and the skeletal remains of ships. Dozens of hulls, some ancient Pact World models, others unrecognizable—fused into a MASSIVE DERELICT STATION. A graveyard welded by forces that do not obey physics.

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - COCKPIT - CONTINUOUS

Clo leans forward, eyes narrowing at the distortion ahead.

CLO
Is that… a shipyard?

Navasi studies it, reading the danger in the shapes.

NAVASI
Not on any registry. Not even a ghost nav point.

CLO
Then what is it?

NAVASI
Graveyard. Or bait dressed like one.

The ship shudders crossing an invisible fringe. The air hums.

CLO
The way those hulls are fused…
melted mid-fold.

NAVASI
Drift junk doesn't do that on its
own.

VEERA (V.O.)
Active glyph remnants detected.
Interference rising. Survival odds…
dropping.

The console glitches, VEERA'S voice distorts, harsh and broken.

VEERA (V.O. / GLITCHING)
A-adviso- sear- distor—don't… leave
me behind-

Navasi freezes, hand on the throttle.

CLO
Veera?

VEERA'S voice snaps back.

VEERA (V.O.)
…But by all means, dock somewhere
sharp.

CLO
Did she just say-?

Navasi doesn't answer. Her hand moves to her jacket. A faint glow pulses beneath, the DRIFTHEART SHARD, reacting.

NAVASI
It knows we're close.

CLO
It?

NAVASI
The Shard. Map, memory… maybe both.

She flips switches, guiding the ship toward a jagged docking pylon jutting from the station's lowest curve.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Veera—sealed gear protocols. Full
mask cycle.

VEERA (V.O.)
Airlock prepped. Tension levels, theatrical.

Navasi cuts forward thrust. The ship glides into position.

A WHISPER brushes inside their heads—not through comms. Not through Veera.

CLO
Did you hear that?

Navasi nods. Eyes forward.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD vibrates against her ribs.

NAVASI
The Vault just exhaled.

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - ARMORY VESTIBULE

Navasi holsters her sidearm, slides a compact resonator pistol into her boot. Clo shoulders a gearpack loaded with scanners and sensor dampeners. At the rack, he hesitates, then grabs a collapsible pulse staff.

NAVASI
No outside broadcasting.
Veera—updates go navcore only.

VEERA (V.O.)
Fine. Just remember who keeps your oxygen scrubbers in tune.

Navasi slaps the panel. The airlock hisses open into the unknown.

EXT. ECHORIFT - MAIN AIRLOCK

The boarding ramp lands with a hollow CLANG, the sound swallowed into the station's depths.

Navasi and Clo step through decompression. Masks hiss, equalizing to a thin, stale pressure.

Flickering red strips smear rusted walls in uneven pulses. The corridor looks grown, not built — metal and polyglass fused like scar tissue.

VEERA (V.O.)
Sensors just froze. Getting partial reads… or Echorift's haunted.

CLO
Not mutually exclusive.

VEERA (V.O. - GLITCHING)
…mutua— exclu—

Static swallows her.

Navasi sweeps a wrist scanner across the hall. HUD blinks: 1:57:21 — AIR REMAINING.

NAVASI
Pressure’s borderline. No O2 feed.

CLO
Two hours, tops?

NAVASI
If the core’s dead. Less if it’s lying.

VEERA (V.O.)
My bet? Don’t breathe deep.

She moves on, pulse pistol ready. Clo follows, eyes on a collapsed ceiling strut, listening to the station’s slow metallic groan.

CLO
Worst case?

NAVASI
We suffocate.

A smile under her mask, razor thin.

They pass a dark console that flickers once, dies. Navasi’s scanner pings, unreadable.

NAVASI (CONT’D)
Whoever built this didn’t want it found.

Clo’s hand brushes etched glyphs, partially melted.

CLO
Drift harmonics. Inverted.

NAVASI
Cancelling something out.

VEERA (V.O.)
And that never ends well for nav cores.

A HUM rises — not mechanical, tonal. The air thickens.

CLO
I don’t like that.

NAVASI
I’ve heard worse.

Her hand touches a shard of fused alloy —

FLASH MEMORY:

— A locked cell door. Younger. Bruised. The ozone sting. A voice: “You’re never walking free again.”

BACK:

Her grip tightens. Clo catches it.

CLO
Nav?

NAVASI
I’m fine.

FOOTSTEPS echo from deep ahead. Both raise weapons. Silence.

A soft CLATTER.

A plush toy, clone-tagged, Drift sensor flickering — tumbles from the dark. Clo stares too long.

NAVASI (CONT’D)
Stay close.

They vanish into the corridor’s throat. A single light dies behind them.

INT. ECHORIFT - AIRLOCK CORRIDOR - MOMENTS LATER

Dim light. Warped deck plates. Clo follows close, boots clicking. Metallic groans shadow each step.

VEERA (V.O. - GLITCHING)
—Va—si… drift… inter—fere-

NAVASI
Route through emergency relays.

VEERA (V.O.)
Copy. If I melt, I’m blaming you.

They round a curve —

Bodies hang in microgravity. Sealed suits. Tethered. Displayed. Visors fogged. Silent.

CLO
Dead?

Navasi scans. No vitals.

NAVASI
Long time.

One suit drifts. Its scorched bio-tag visible.

CLO
Clone lot number.

NAVASI
Look at the emblem.

A faded symbol above, GENETEK VAULT DIVISION.

She lingers on one tag, something in it hitting deep.

CLO
Why hang them like this?

NAVASI
So we'd find them.

One visor glows —

A SHOCKWAVE BLASTS out. Gravity bends. Clo SLAMS into a beam. Navasi catches an anchor line, hauls him in. Light warps, sound drops out for a heartbeat.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Drift wake. Memory trigger.

CLO
This place thinks.

VEERA (V.O. - DISTORTED)
Warn- drift-field anom-

Silence. The station exhales. They move on deeper.

EXT. ECHORIFT - INNER CORRIDORS - LATER

They push through hanging tethers and limp bodies. HUDs blink red in their visors. Navasi finds a recessed panel and cracks it open — a sharp HISS, scanner light flaring green.

NAVASI
Pressure loop’s intact.

She removes her mask. Clo follows suit.

CLO
Can’t believe I’m saying this, but I missed air.

NAVASI
Don’t fall in love. It’s borrowed.

Sparks snap in the shadows. Then—

VEERA (V.O.)
Pressure nominal. Glyph trace… detectable.

CLO
Glyph trace? Veera, triangulate.

VEERA (V.O.)
Trying. Signal’s recursive. Echo folding over itself.
(glitching)
…Navasi… you left us… you left me…

Navasi freezes mid-step. Her eyes track to a dead console.

CLO
Did she just—?

NAVASI
That wasn’t her. Not all the way.

VEERA (V.O.)
That line… was not in my system log.

She wipes sweat, forces herself forward.

NAVASI
Keep trying. If anything moves, scream.

A helmet on a tether slowly turns, visor watching her. Navasi spots a shard of metal wedged in the wall, pulls it free. A battered sigil. Her old crew.

CLO
You okay?

NAVASI
No. But I will be.

She pockets it.

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT CHAMBER - MOMENTS LATER

They cross a threshold etched with faded GLYPHS. Four concentric rings glow faintly. The chamber opens into a cathedral of metal, vaulted ceilings, four MONOLITHIC PILLARS encircling a CIRCULAR PLATFORM. Broken consoles hang in the air above, tethered to nothing. At the center, a PEDESTAL turns in slow, deliberate rotation.

Each pillar bears a SUN — one red, one blue, one yellow, one green.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD in Navasi's jacket pulses harder now, heat blooming through the fabric.

CLO
It's humming.

NAVASI
Not air pressure. Aetheric feedback.

The nearest glyphs ripple faintly. Veera's voice breaks through — ragged.

VEERA (V.O. - GLITCHING)
Ambient resonance… not compatible with Drift equations… [signal fragment]-

CLO
It's syncing with the shard.

NAVASI
It's not unlocking a door. It's remembering me.

She steps to the pedestal. A floating interface ring hovers above it, slightly off-center.

CLO
"Only the true path lights the four suns."

NAVASI
Drift harmonics. Like tuning an engine by ear. But older.

She closes her eyes. Hands move, aligning the ring. A deep tone reverberates — the Red Sun flares.

CLO
That's one.

The shard burns hot against her chest. Blue and Yellow ignite in quick succession — the air thickens, gravity bending subtly.

VEERA (V.O.)
Aetheric saturation climbing. Shard response escalating. Navasi, your biosigns—

CLO
You sure about this?

NAVASI
No. But the Vault is.

She twists the final alignment — the Green Sun flares. All four blaze at once. The pedestal SINKS, revealing a yawning GRAVITY WELL below, glowing with a slow, predatory thrum.

The vibration builds, not just sound, but pressure in their bones. A presence rises from deep beneath, watching.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Vault's listening.
(beat)
Let's hear what it has to say.

The pull from the well grows stronger, drawing them in whether they want it or not. Clo braces against a pillar.

CLO
Uh… Nav?

NAVASI
Too late.

The platform tilts. They're pulled toward the light and swallowed whole.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - DESCENT SHAFT / ANTECHAMBER - LOW LIGHT

CLO lands hard. Dust plumes upward. His pulse staff clatters, rolling into shadow.

NAVASI drops behind him, silent, controlled. Breathing steady.

A low tremor rolls through the stone beneath their boots. The air feels thick, almost listening.

Clo taps his helmet light. Flicker. Weak beam.

Navasi taps hers twice—steady glow.

She turns to him.

NAVASI
It's not the power. It's the rhythm.
(beat)
Give it tempo. Not orders.

She moves her wrist—light pulsing in sync with her steps.

Clo tries. Too rigid. His beam stutters.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
You're wrestling it.

CLO
That's kinda my default.

NAVASI
Let it read you. You don't command light. You accompany it.

She moves, fluid, precise. A kata in slow motion. The dust swirls in time with her.

Clo watches. Mimics. Stumbles.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Shoulder down. Elbow soft.

She adjusts him, brief contact, then gone. Not intimate. Real.

CLO
This what you did to survive?

NAVASI
This is what I did… so surviving didn't turn me into someone else.
(beat)
Movement teaches you where your ghosts live.

Clo steadies. His light begins to match hers—but shifts, resonating a fraction off her tempo.

The walls answer. A faint vibration. Dust lifts and hangs in midair, suspended.

CLO
You ever wish someone taught you like this?

Navasi pauses.

NAVASI
Yeah. Every day.

Their beams lock. A harmonic tone blooms in the chamber.

CLO
What's that?

NAVASI
Acknowledgment. Vault's listening.

She steps back. He holds the stance—centered.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
You're not just lighting the way.
(beat)
You're mapping the dark.

A shadow shifts deep in the passage ahead—long, deliberate.

CLO
Then let's see where it goes.

He powers the pulse staff. A low hum joins the tone in the walls.

She gives the faintest nod.

They move forward. Together.

The walls pulse once—like a slow heartbeat—as the shadows swallow them.

EXT. ECHORIFT - DESCENT SHAFT / SUBLEVEL ANTECHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The pull from the well fades. The harmonic tone from the Vault still hums faintly, carried in the walls.

Dust settles around NAVASI and CLO as they move down a narrow passage — light still synced between their steps.

They reach a sealed alcove ahead.

INT. ECHORIFT - REST CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

A meditation vault. Cracked floor tiles. Fractured glass. Breathable air — faint hum of stabilized gravity.

Navasi steps in first. Removes her mask. Breathes.

Clo lingers at the doorway, scanning.

She exhales, then a sharp CHIRP cuts through the quiet from her wrist-comm.

THAEL (V.O., STATIC)
-Navi? Is that you? Gods, tell me this isn't a loop—

She freezes. Her eyes harden.

NAVASI
Thael. You're not supposed to—

THAEL (V.O.)
I know. I know. Listen — I flagged your tag. That AstraCorp-coded ping you used—

Her gaze sharpens.

THAEL (V.O.)
—it's Vault-aligned, Navasi. You think this is salvage? It's bait.

NAVASI
You need to get off this frequency—

THAEL (V.O.)
They're coming for you. For all of us—

The signal warps — a sharp, tearing DISTORTION.

NAVASI
Thael—?

THAEL (V.O., GLITCHING)
—just wanted to say— —wasn't lying—

The voice shreds into static. Gone.

Navasi stays still. Doesn't blink. Her fingers tremble once.

Clo steps in, catching only the tail end of static.

CLO
What was that?

NAVASI
Just interference.

CLO
No it wasn't.

A long beat. She doesn't meet his eyes.

NAVASI
(quietly)
No. It wasn't.

At her side, the DRIFTHEART SHARD flares — faint pulses syncing with the comm's dying distortion. Recognition. Connection.

Overhead, a corridor light flickers. A faint WHISPER carries through, Navasi's own voice from the shaft.

VOICE
(whisper)
You're not just lighting the way…

She stops. The Vault's harmonic undertone rides beneath the whisper.

The voice fades. She exhales. Hand clenched. Grief held like a blade.

CLO
You ok?

NAVASI
Yeah. Just echoes.

She moves for the exit without looking back.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. THE DRIFT - THAEL'S SHIP

Floating in starless black. Silent.

A faint signal pulses from within, same frequency as the Driftheart, bent, distorted.

Something watches.

A shimmer — space folding in on itself. Not a jump. A CLAIM.

A CORPSE FLEET glyph flickers on the HUD. This time it lingers, pulsing in sync with the shard.

Then —

Thael's ship collapses inward. Crushed. Disintegrated.

Gone.

CUT TO:

EXT. UNKNOWN LOCATION - OBSERVATION CHAMBER

Static flickers across a fractured wall of monitors. One feed shows Navasi in real-time, moving deeper into the shadowed corridors of ECHORIFT. Others loop ghost images — fragments of past missions, impossible futures, and distorted doubles.

Draeth stands before them, fingers hovering over a stim vial — not yet injected. The restraint costs him.

In the deepest corner of the chamber, reality warps, the UNDEAD ENFORCER bleeds into existence. Armor slick with neural rot. A face like cracked obsidian. Its presence bends the air, tilts the shadows.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
You feel. Still. That is your flaw.

Draeth doesn't look away from Navasi's feed. The curve of her shoulders, the set of her jaw — familiar, almost painfully so.

DRAETH
She was never supposed to go this far.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
And yet… here she is. Echoing louder than your silence.

A faint SHUDDER in the walls, distant, muffled. Draeth's eyes flick to another monitor, the CORPSE FLEET DREADNOUGHT, lurking in the starless Drift, where Thael's ship used to be. Debris fields spin in slow, silent arcs.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
You failed to claim the Rift Vault.
Failed to contain the resonance.
Flesh wavers. Code endures.

DRAETH
I told you I'd deliver her. Alive.
You said that mattered.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
It no longer does. If she will not yield the shards… reclaim them. By any means.

Draeth's reflection stares back at him in the monitor, fractured, split between feeds.

DRAETH
She's not like the others.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
No. She remembers. That makes her dangerous.

The Enforcer's form shifts, not moving, but appearing closer, as if space itself folds to obey.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
You tremble. Shall I send another?

DRAETH
No.
(beat)
She's mine to finish.

The Enforcer withdraws into the air itself, leaving the room colder, thinner.

Draeth studies Navasi's image one last time as she disappears deeper into the vault shadows. His thumb hovers over a console control, a hunter's command waiting to be given.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
I'll bring her in.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
Do not delay. The Drift already sings her name.

Off Draeth's haunted stare —

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - DESCENT SHAFT / SUBLEVEL ANTECHAMBER - LATER

Residual light from the Vault's pull still burns in their retinas, drifting halos, like afterimages of a dying star.

The corridor breathes unease, walls faintly pulsing with Driftlight, as if remembering who passed through. The air is dense, charged. Every step feels watched. Every surface listens.

Overhead fixtures buzz, shadows fracture but never settle.

Navasi moves with precision, but her rhythm is off, a faint tremor in her grip.

She taps her torch twice. It steadies.

VEERA (V.O., GLITCHING)
Ambient resonance…
de-de-detrimental drift bleed
spike—

NAVASI
Veera, stabilize sublayer comms.
Prioritize thermal logic and
baseline memory integrity.

VEERA (V.O., STABILIZING)
Copy. Baseline locked. Memory
echoes… still persistent.

From the walls, a pulse. Faint. Rhythmic. A heartbeat.

At the edge of the hall —

A DRIFT-ETCHED ICON glows faintly in the debris.

Navasi kneels. Picks it up.

It’s a twisted shard of Vault insignia, older than anything that should remain. The same pattern Draeth wore.

She closes her hand around it before Clo notices.

NAVASI
Let’s move.

They vanish into the dark. Behind them, the light dies, one beat too late.

EXT. ECHORIFT - DARKENED CORRIDOR - MOMENTS LATER

Twin beams of light slice the pitch.

The walls are smoother here. Less decay, more intent. Glyphs carved in faintly backlit patterns.

CLO
They're reactive. Look, your light's waking them up.

He sweeps his beam. Ripples of light chase across stone.

NAVASI
Psionic imprinting. This was never abandoned. Just sealed.

Their footsteps echo too slowly, sound catching in the air.

CLO
Feels… compressed.

NAVASI
Temporal lensing. The Drift bends pressure in strange ways.

They round a corner —

A skeletal figure slumped against the wall. Armor shattered. Hand outstretched.

CLO
He was crawling.

Navasi crouches. Examines the fused fingers, melted into the floor.

NAVASI
No. Reaching.

She brushes away dust, revealing a faint pressure plate under his hand.

CLO
Trap trigger.

NAVASI
Or failsafe.

She scans the ceiling. Her light catches hair-thin wires crisscrossing the hall.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Clo. Don't move.

He freezes, inches from one of the threads.

CLO
How did he make it this far?

NAVASI
Maybe it didn’t trigger for him.

CLO
He wasn’t… like us.

She nods. Unclipping her belt torch, she flips a switch — emits a steady pulse.

A shimmer rolls through the hall. Every wire catches the light — a deadly web.

NAVASI
Follow my exact steps.

They move slow. Precise. The kata from earlier echoing in their footwork. Step by step, breath controlled.

A hum builds in the walls. Something watches.

They reach the far side.

NAVASI (CONT’D)
You okay, Stray?

CLO
Still mapping the dark.

She almost smiles.

NAVASI
Good.

They move on.

INT. ECHORIFT - MEDICAL RESEARCH RING - LATER

Flickering lights stutter overhead.

The corridor narrows, angular, sterile. Rust gnaws at wall plating. Half the doors frozen shut, others yawning open to dust-choked chambers.

Clo sweeps his scanner over a flickering panel. It BEEPS.

CLO
Localized power bleed. Ahead.
Second room left.

INT. ECHORIFT - PRESERVATION BAY - CONTINUOUS

Colder here. A thin mist hugs the floor. Frost webs across cryopods stacked three high.

Some shattered. Some dead. One glows faint blue.

Navasi approaches, gun ready. Clo follows, quieter now.

She wipes frost from the glass —

A CHILD inside. Maybe nine. CLONED. Same faint facial linework as Clo — younger, softer.

Clo steps forward.

CLO
(softly)
They were children.

A name tag: SUBJECT 87-9B. Below, a printed label —

CYCLE GROUP: Beta-Y4 (Neuroplastic Sync Protocol)

SPONSOR: AstraCorp Biomedical - Drift Division

STATUS: BEHAVIORAL ENCODING PHASE INTERRUPTED

CLO (CONT'D)
Not even a name.

Navasi activates the pod's terminal. It buzzes, then flashes:

· RECOVERY FAILED

· STASIS INTERRUPTED

· DATA SCRUB INCOMPLETE

CLO (CONT'D)
There were more, weren't there?

NAVASI
Dozens. Maybe more.

A cracked data-slate on the floor glows faintly, STAGE 2 SUBJECT: UNRESPONSIVE. Nearby, monitoring cuffs lie abandoned beside a blood-smeared surgical tray.

CLO
Why keep them here?

NAVASI
This wasn’t research. It was containment.

A low HUM builds. Lights flicker. Clo’s wristpad CRACKLES.

CLO
Another signal. Deeper.

Navasi rests a hand on the glass, just for a moment.

NAVASI
Let’s keep moving.

They exit. The mist curls in their wake.

Behind them, a flickering pod blinks to life for a heartbeat — then dies.

Something still watches.

CUT TO:

INT. DRAETH’S FLAGSHIP - OBSERVATION DECK - DRIFTSPACE

Cold light spills through crystalline viewports, catching on matte-black armor and mirrored display panels.

DRAETH stands alone — controlled, measured. Not emotionless, but carved hollow by purpose.

Beyond the glass, the Drift shifts in unnatural hues, strands of warped space shimmering like liquid glass. Somewhere out there, the shadow of a CORPSE FLEET CRUISER drifts in the dark — silent, waiting.

A HOLO-MAP floats beside him. ECHORIFT pulses steadily. No longer a mystery — a node he’s hunted for years.

An OFFICER approaches — corporate military, clean-cut, but with the faint unease of someone aware they’re standing too close to something dangerous.

OFFICER
Telemetry confirms it, sir. The Rough Draft has breached the outer wards. Descending to sublevels now — just as projected.

DRAETH
We’ve guided every step.

OFFICER
Do we deploy interceptors to follow them in?

DRAETH
(shakes his head)
No. Let them believe the reliquary is theirs to claim. The deeper they go, the more the Vault will mark them.

The officer hesitates.

OFFICER
And if they deviate from path?

DRAETH
Then we adapt. But they won't. The shard's pull will keep her aligned.

He turns from the viewport — his reflection fractured by the glass. For an instant, the faint ghost of his wife and daughter lingers there. Then it's gone.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Once the inner gate opens, deploy collectors. Prioritize intact glyph-tech and any living memory imprints.

OFFICER
And if they resist?

DRAETH
(contemplative)
She won't. Not yet. She still thinks she has a choice.

CUT TO:

INT. FLAGSHIP - MONITOR BAY - SIMULTANEOUS

Dim surveillance feeds flicker. One shows Navasi mid-step in a Drift-lit corridor. The DRIFTHEART's pulse glows faintly from her jacket. Clo's heat signature flickers beside her.

Sensor data scrolls — spike activity, active glyph response, residual tether readings.

DRAETH (V.O.)
Let them walk the myth. Let them think they're unlocking it.

The ECHORIFT feed distorts — a shimmer of the Corpse Fleet glyph ripples across the static before fading.

DRAETH (V.O.)
When the Vault remembers, it won't be for them.

Off Draeth's haunted stare —

FADE OUT.

INT. ECHORIFT - LOWER ARCHIVAL VAULT - LATER

The corridor tightens, swallowing them in shadow. Residual Driftlight hums faintly through hidden conduits, like the place is still breathing.

Clo runs his fingers over the walls. Symmetrical glyphwork stirs under his touch, faint as dying embers.

CLO
Not Vesk. Not Castrovelian.
(beat)
I've seen these before… in the cryopod schematics.

That stops Navasi.

NAVASI
Same glyphs?

CLO
Not exact. But the curves… the loops… like someone taught them to write with broken memories.

NAVASI
Driftborn languages. Fractal. Built in echoes.

Clo flicks his scanner. It sputters, fighting static.

CLO
Same interference band as the first fragment.

They step through a melted doorway, metal edges curled inward. Beyond: a collapsed lab, ceiling snapped like bones, dust hanging in the still air.

At the center, half-buried, a pedestal. Beside it, a shattered containment case, stabilizer coil blinking a faint red.

Navasi brushes ash and glass aside revealing a metallic shard, palm-sized, carved in the same glyphs.

NAVASI
This is what they built around.

She lifts it. It thrums in her grip. The SHARD flares bright, then flickers, unfocused.

A vision hits her: the Vault gate dissolving space… a scream folding backward into silence.

CLO
Navasi?

NAVASI
It’s showing me something.

The walls shiver. Lights pulse, answering her.

CLO
Signal spike. Minimal radiation.
It’s… reacting to you.

She turns it over. Beneath the glyphs, a stamped serial tag.

KEY FRAGMENT 3B - RUNECORE INTERLOCK / SITE: ECHORIFT

NAVASI
(under her breath)
Interlock. It’s not whole.

The pedestal clicks. A panel slides open. Inside, a set of long-drained microfusion capacitors and a cracked tablet.

Clo powers it. Static resolves into a schematic:

FOUR INTERLOCK SITES DETECTED - STATUS: INACTIVE

CLO
There are more. Not just here.

NAVASI
Four keys… or four locks.

A deep metallic groan rolls through the vault. Not from the lab. From above.

CLO
We’re not alone.

She pockets the shard. It pulses once, low and resonant, like a heartbeat that isn’t hers. Her pupils contract. A shiver runs through her.

NAVASI
We move. Now.

They slip into the dark. Behind them, the wall glyphs begin pulsing in new, accelerating patterns. as if the Vault itself just woke up.

CUT TO:

INT. DRAETH'S FLAGSHIP - OBSERVATION DECK - SAME MOMENT

Cold light spills through crystalline viewports, refracting across the matte-black armor plates and fractured holographics that hang in the air like frozen shards.

Draeth stands at the center, one hand braced on the tactical console. The schematic of ECHORIFT pulses steadily, but now a second pulse overlays it. The DRIFTHEART's signature. Violent. Immediate.

He flinches. Not from surprise, from pain.

His other hand rises to his neck. Veins there flare faintly, crawling with residual glyph-light as if the shard's tether is burning through him from a distance.

A shadow bleeds into the space beside him. The ENFORCER. Not entering—simply there. Warping the light.

ENFORCER
One wakes. And you fracture.

DRAETH
It's in my head. Like the Vault slammed a door… and locked it from the inside.

ENFORCER
You were marked once. You remain marked still.

Draeth steadies himself against the console, eyes locked on the feed of Navasi moving deeper into the Vault.

DRAETH
She's syncing with it.

ENFORCER
And every beat pulls her beyond your reach.

DRAETH
Not if I end this before the pattern completes.

The Enforcer drifts closer, not walking, not gliding, simply existing nearer. The light around its form bends inward.

ENFORCER
If she reaches the fourth interlock—

DRAETH
(snarling)
—Then I'll be the one waiting there.

A faint ripple in the viewport glass. Far out in the Drift, a massive silhouette slides between stars. Predatory. The CORPSE FLEET vessel, phase-cloaked, still lurking from when it devoured Thael's ship.

Draeth doesn't look away from the ECHORIFT display.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Deploy the Echo Cell. And keep the Fleet in the dark until I give the order.

ENFORCER
(whispering silk)
Do not delay. The Drift is already singing her name.

Draeth's gaze hardens, the glyph-light in his neck slowly dimming—but not dying.

DRAETH
Then I'll answer it first.

Off his reflection in the glass, a man caught between hunter and hunted.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - MID-LEVEL SHAFT ACCESS - MOMENTS LATER

A tremor rolls underfoot, faint but rhythmic, like the heartbeat of something buried deep.

Navasi and Clo emerge from a crumbling bulkhead into a narrow stairwell lit by dying emergency strips. The light flickers to that same rhythm.

They pause. Listen.

Somewhere above or below, soft metal-on-metal. A shifting presence.

Navasi rests a hand on the wall. It hums.

NAVASI
(low)
This place doesn't just echo. It remembers.

Clo adjusts his gear, scanning upward through the shaft.

CLO
We've walked through ghosts before. This one hums louder.

They move downward, slow, careful — swallowed by the gloom.

INT. ECHORIFT - STABILIZED CORRIDOR - POST-RUNE DISCOVERY

Navasi pushes open a bent hatch. Beyond, a sealed control hall flickers weakly.

Her scanner blinks green.

NAVASI
Air's holding. Enough for a breather.

Clo lowers his mask fully, savoring the dry, artificial air.

CLO
We stopping?

NAVASI
Ten minutes max. Power's low, but this pocket will damp Drift noise. Get off your feet.

CLO
And you?

NAVASI
Looping a sensor grid. We still don't know what's moving in here.

She rests a hand on his shoulder — firm — then disappears down the corridor, pistol drawn.

▯

INT. ECHORIFT - SEALED CLONE HOLD - MOMENTS LATER

Clo enters. Silent. Intact. Broken cryo-pods line the walls, amber Genetek symbols barely visible under frost.

He sits, breathes. The DRIFTHEART SHARD rests against his chest, faintly glowing.

The air is still. Not peaceful, waiting.

He closes his eyes.

INT. VOID SPACE - DREAMSCAPE

Darkness. But alive.

The Drift churns like a living ocean overhead. From below: hands. Hundreds of cloned hands breaching liquid black.

A CHORUS OF WHISPERS, indecipherable, then one voice, close.

VOICE (O.S.)
You are the echo of a stolen name.

He tries to move, limbs glitch, stutter. From the dark, a face rises.

Older. Scarred. Him.

OLDER CLO
You're not ready.

A shadow forms beyond the stars — watching. A flicker of Draeth's reflection, tall, still, as if in a mirror.

VOICE (O.S.)
You are not alone.

The SHARD burns white — a shock of light.

INT. ECHORIFT - SEALED CLONE HOLD - CONTINUOUS

Clo jolts awake. Breathing hard. The shard still glows.

A faint, inhuman CLICKING begins.

He grabs his staff. Stands.

A shape moves across the far threshold. Not Navasi.

From the dark corridor — XEL'THI.

A tall, weathered Shirren female. Chitin dulled with age, one compound eye fractured. A ragged biosilk cloak stitched with old interface ports and drifting glyphwork. Calm. Measured.

She steps forward, one hand extended.

XEL'THI
You wear borrowed breath.

CLO
Stay back. I'm armed.

XEL'THI
If I meant you harm, you'd still be dreaming.

She studies him, scanning. Not hostile, but… weighing.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
Clone-stock. But not shattered.

CLO
What?

XEL'THI
The ones before you, broken echoes. But you… hold.

She kneels, cloak pooling. Produces a cracked Drift-focus lens. Places it near the shard. It hums.

CLO
You know what that is?

XEL'THI
A question carved into silence.

CLO
And you?

XEL'THI
One who stayed behind. One who remembers what the others chose to forget.

NAVASI (O.S.)
Clo?

He turns — relief.

Navasi steps in, gun raised. Freezes when she sees Xel'thi.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Who the hell—

XEL'THI
Captain.

A subtle reverence.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
Your footsteps stir what sleeps.

NAVASI
That's not always a good thing.

XEL'THI
It is here.

The shard pulses brighter, resonating with all three of them.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
The station is waking. You've already walked too far to turn back.

A low tremor rumbles through the floor. Glyphs on the walls shift pattern, loop by loop.

NAVASI
Then forwards the only way.

They head into the flickering hall. The glyphs ripple in their wake, as if following.

INT. ECHORIFT - INNER VAULT ENTRYWAY - MOMENTS LATER

The faint PULSE of the DRUFTHEART still lingers from the last chamber, its glow catching in the glyphs carved into the walls.

XEL'THI
There are layers here that shouldn't exist. The Vault is shifting, responding.

She trails her hand near the wall. A shimmer ripples out, the glyphs tightening, then spiraling inward.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
This place wasn't built. It was remembered into being.

CLO
Like it has memory?

XEL'THI
More than memory. Intention.

The glyphs retract fully, revealing a jagged corridor lit by a slow, breathing Driftlight.

NAVASI
An invitation?

CLO
Or bait.

The Vault's light flares — a slow, deep THRUM — as if it heard them. They exchange a glance and step in.

INT. ECHORIFT - HARMONIC CONSOLE NODE - CONTINUOUS

The narrow corridor spills onto a suspended control platform above a gulf of black. The air here HUMS in the bones.

At its center, a fractured HARMONIC CONSOLE, glyphwork fractured, casting violet waves across their faces.

Xel'thi approaches with the care of a priest at an altar. Her hands sweep the air above the interface, a kata, slow and precise.

CLO
That thing's older than Drifttech.
How do you even know it works?

XEL'THI
Because it still remembers what it
was built for.

A ripple answers her touch — light rolling outward like a breath. Fractured glyphs knit together.

NAVASI
Don't distract her. This is…
delicate.

The console emits that same HARMONIC TONE from the Vault's earlier awakening. Xel'thi flinches, steadying herself.

CLO
You've heard it before.

XEL'THI
Not heard. Dreamed.

Her eyes stay on the shifting waveforms.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
Before the Drift, my people lived
by harmonic attunement.
(MORE)

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
When the Fold collapsed, it took our homeworld with it. And yet…
(touches her temple)
…sometimes I wake to this sound. Like something calling me back.

The sequence completes. A projection blooms above the console, a city frozen in time, drifting under dying starlight.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
That's what the Fold took from us.

CLO
And if we find it?

XEL'THI
Then maybe I stop serving the past… and start living for something else.

The harmonic fades, but the glow lingers faintly in her eyes. Navasi clocks it — just for a beat — then looks to the next corridor.

From the console, a single glyph flares RED before fading. Somewhere deep below, a low RUMBLE answers.

NAVASI
We keep moving.

They cross the platform into the dark.

INT. ECHORIFT - CORE SHAFT ACCESS - MOMENTS LATER

The last harmonic tones from the console still seem to cling to the air. The walls breathe with faint glyph-light, pulsing like a heartbeat guiding them forward.

Mechanical doors stutter open and snap shut. Somewhere deep in the Vault, forgotten systems groan back to life. Red hazard strobes sputter weakly, bathing the corridor in broken pulses.

A surveillance drone drifts into view. Its hull is veined with drift-glass, as if the Vault has begun to assimilate it. Optics dilate, scanning —

— and freeze.

Ahead, a containment structure. Shattered from within. Lock mechanisms scored with deep claw marks. Burnt override panels. Not random, surgical.

The drone chirps an urgent alert.

Something moves behind it.

CRACK, the drone convulses, arcs of violet static tearing through it. It slams to the deck, twitching, then still.

The lights flicker. Once. Twice. Then darkness.

A heavy EXHALE — wet, inhuman — rolls through the ruptured corridor.

And then —

Two eyes flare open in the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - OBSIDIAN CHASM - CONTINUOUS

Navasi, Clo, and Xel'thi BURST through a narrowing hatch, breath sharp, boots pounding. Distant METALLIC SCREECHES echo after them, the sound of something hunting.

They skid to a halt at the ledge of a massive vertical chasm plunging into the station's heart. The walls shimmer with iridescent drift-glass, light coursing like liquid through veins of stone.

Suspended at the void's center: a narrow vertical OBELISK, its glyphwork alive with shifting patterns. Time seems to bend around it.

A flickering MAINTENANCE BRIDGE stretches toward it, half-real, half-ghost, phasing in and out. The air snaps with static charge.

NAVASI
(under her breath)
And here I was missing stairs.

CLO
That obelisk… it's tuned to Drift interference. Feels like it's holding time at arm's length.

XEL'THI
Time here is wounded. And wounds… either heal or they rot.

Navasi snaps a MAGNETIC TETHER into place and leaps — almost vertical — landing on a fractured glyph-ledge.

NAVASI
Bridge is shot. Manual climb only.

Clo follows. Boots scrape. The glyphs beneath them glow faintly, syncing to their breath.

CLO
You don’t have to go first every time, you know.

NAVASI
Too late to argue now.

Below, Xel’thi lingers, antennae angled, whispering something too low to catch — prayer or calculation.

Clo pushes for another ledge, catches it, but the ancient metal GROANS. It gives way.

CLO
Navasi!

She whips around, grabs his wrist just before he vanishes into the chasm. The weight yanks her forward, boots skidding, shoulder tearing with pain.

Below, an endless drop into raw Drift energy arcing between walls.

CLO (CONT’D)
Let go! You’ll fall!

NAVASI
(gritted)
Not my style.

Her fingers, bloody now, find purchase in a jagged glyph-slit. Muscles strain, breath ragged, then, with a roar, she hauls him up.

They collapse together, hearts pounding in sync.

CLO
You always this dramatic?

NAVASI
Only for the ones I don’t hate.

They rise. Ahead. a circular platform. Glyphs pulse faintly across its surface, patterns shifting as they approach.

CLO
Same symbols from the clone hold.

NAVASI
Part of the experiments.

CLO
Not a key… a filter. Passage or rejection.

She nods. He adjusts a glyph.

CLICK, a radiant PULSE surges outward. For a suspended moment, all motion freezes, dust midair, breath caught — then STAIRS SPIRAL INTO BEING above them, unfolding like a memory.

NAVASI
Great. More stairs.

They climb. The Vault listens.

Each step triggers a chorus of glyphs, reading them. Judging them.

CLO
It's watching us.

NAVASI
No… weighing us.

The final glyph SEARS underfoot — the last test.

They pass.

Gravity slips its grip. The air tastes metallic. A low vibration hums through their bones as the VAULT OPENS ABOVE.

They rise into the unknown.

CUT TO:

INT. DRAETH'S FLAGSHIP - OBSERVATION DECK - SAME

Cold light bleeds through crystalline viewports, refracting across black armor and mirrored displays. The DRIFT outside writhes in impossible colors.

Before Draeth, a HOLO-SCHEMATIC of the Vault surges with unstable energy. Glyph patterns ripple in harmonic waves, syncing to a jagged, rising pulse.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
If she reaches the fourth, containment collapses.

DRAETH
She’s already touched the second.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
Then stop her.

Draeth doesn’t look away from the schematic. The flares match his own heartbeat. He presses a hand to his neck, veins faintly glowing with the shard’s tether, pulsing in time.

DRAETH
If I move too early, we lose the shard. I will decide when.

A beat. Then the Enforcer’s form warps closer, a cold fold in space.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
Indecision costs. The Corpse Fleet drifts at your perimeter. They smell the breach. They will claim it if you do not.

Draeth’s eyes flick to a secondary feed, a dark silhouette in Drift space, Fleet glyph faintly burning on its hull.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
They are already sifting the wreck of the one called Thael.

His jaw tightens. The schematic flares again, one glyph burning hotter, brighter, as if calling to him.

DRAETH
There.

The Enforcer’s voice coils in closer, almost inside his skull.

ENFORCER (V.O.)
Then act. Or I will send another.

DRAETH
(firm)
No. She’s mine to finish.

He turns sharply, cloak snapping behind him.

DRAETH (CONT’D)
Deploy the Echo Cell. Lock the lower vault strata. And seal her exit. If the Vault wants her, it will have to go through me.

The schematic’s pulse grows violent, heartbeat and Driftlight now perfectly in sync, Draeth’s breath matching it like a man walking into the pull of a tide.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - GLYPH STAIRWAY SUMMIT - CONTINUOUS

Clo lands hard on the narrow crown. It sways under him — unstable, ancient.

Navasi joins a beat later, catching her breath. Eyes the dizzying drop below.

NAVASI
You good?

CLO
Does this platform usually vibrate?

The glyphs beneath their boots BURN BRIGHTER, not steady, but flickering like warning strobes.

Far below, shadows writhe along the spiral. The last of the stairs unravel behind them, dissolving into the dark.

Xel’thi stands motionless, antennae twitching like sensors struck by static.

XEL’THI
The guardian stirs.

A low reverberation hums through the stone, a pressure wave more felt than heard.

CLO
Didn’t we already beat the last one?

NAVASI
Different energy. This isn’t a sentry—

A jagged gust of air sweeps upward. Dry. Metallic. Laced with decay.

CLO
Something’s breathing.

XEL’THI
This one does not sleep. It waits.

The light above dims, not from failure, but from something vast eclipsing it.

NAVASI
Eyes up. Move careful. Whatever's ahead… it's not just guarding something. It's hunting.

They step forward. The summit path narrows. Another EXHALE — closer now.

INT. ECHORIFT - OBELISK CORE - SAME

The crystalline heart at the obelisk's center fractures. Vents of raw Drift-light swirl outward — liquid lightning bleeding from a divine wound. A low, inhuman GROWL builds.

The VAULT GLYPHS SCREAM, a harmonic distortion that rattles the bone.

INT. ECHORIFT - SUMMIT PLATFORM - SAME

The stairs behind them SPLINTER into nothing. The platform BUCKS under their feet.

A SEISMIC DETONATION, and the OBELISK SPLITS OPEN.

From within —

THE GUARDIAN.

Ten feet tall. Forged from obsidian alloy and half-living DRIFTBONE. Limbs crackle with fusion energy. One arm ends in a serrated blade; the other, a cannon grafted with ancient arcane tech. Its core, a crystalline shard, pulses with Vault resonance.

CLO
Vault Guardian.

NAVASI
Weak point's the crystal! Center chest!

The GUARDIAN LUNGES.

It slams Clo with seismic force, HURLING him across the summit. He SLAMS into a stone spire, breath knocked out, blood streaking down his temple.

A plasma arc SCORCHES where Navasi stood. She rolls, draws her weapon, fires. Bolts ricochet harmlessly off armor.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Veera, I need its spellcore signature NOW.

VEERA (V.O.)
Diverting shield feedback — combat glyph port open.

Navasi slides to a flickering glyph panel in the floor. Yanks a cable from her gauntlet — CONNECTS. Arcane circuitry races across her armor.

She SLAMS her palm down. Energy coils up her arm, fusing to the scar on her wrist like living ink.

CLO
(dazed, yelling)
Whatever you're doing, do it faster!

The GUARDIAN'S cannon charges — fires. The blast misses Navasi by inches but OBLITERATES a nearby column. Stone shrapnel slices her cheek.

She doesn't flinch. Channels more power. Veins GLOW. SLAMS the glyph again.

A SHOCKWAVE detonates outward. The GUARDIAN STAGGERS, its core crystal fissures.

Clo, limping, snaps a charge from his belt, activates it.

CLO (CONT'D)
Catch.

She tosses the fissure a shot — he sends the charge flying.

BOOM.

The crystal SHATTERS. The GUARDIAN SHRIEKS — alien, metallic — collapsing inward like a dying star.

Silence.

Navasi drops to one knee, panting. Holds out her hand.

NAVASI
First rule of climbing obelisks, there's always a guardian.

Clo eyes her hand, hesitates. Then grips her forearm. She hauls him up.

INT. ECHORIFT - OBELISK CHASM BASE - SAME

Far below, Xel'thi raises both hands. MYSTIC CURE arcs from her palms, a comet trail of light weaving upward through fractured beams and broken gravity fields.

CLO (O.S.)
Was that… magic?

NAVASI (O.S.)
She patched you up from sixty meters.

The CHASM RUMBLES. From the dark —

A SECOND GUARDIAN.

Massive. Older. Half-formed, cables for sinew, eyes flickering like dying stars.

Xel'thi reacts instantly. CASTS WALL OF FORCE — a shimmering barrier SLAMS into place as the construct HITS.

She completes a slow, deliberate circle with her hands — PHASE STEP.

Reality bends. A ripple of refracted light arcs up the chasm, spirals — and she's gone.

INT. ECHORIFT - SUMMIT PLATFORM - MOMENTS LATER

Xel'thi reappears beside them in a burst of chromatic shimmer.

CLO
You just—

XEL'THI
Moved.

NAVASI
That's one word for it.

The obelisk HUMS again. Final glyphs light in sequence, cascading upward.

Clo's CHEST FRAGMENT pulses, deep, resonant. One glyph rearranges… forming a FACE.

His face.

Glitched. Warped. Its mouth moves in distorted whispers, fragments of a language he almost understands, before peeling into static.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Clo…

XEL'THI
The Vault is beginning to remember you.

NAVASI
Remember, or recreate?

The glyph-FACE flickers, splinters apart, light collapsing into a narrow beam aimed into the next corridor. The air vibrates, urging them forward.

XELTHI
That depends on which echo it favors.

They step toward the beam and the platform begins to move.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT ANTECHAMBER - LATER

The chamber breathes.

Glyphs pulse dimly across fractured walls, their light stuttering like a heartbeat out of rhythm. The silence is thick, loaded, as if the Vault itself is holding its breath.

Navasi steps in first, dust-streaked, a thin line of blood drying along her cheek. Clo follows, limping slightly from the climb, the adrenaline of the Guardian fight still ghosting in his eyes. A faint vibration runs through the floor beneath their boots, an echo of that battle's dying resonance.

Clo's gaze catches on a BLACKENED BASIN at the center of the room. The symbols carved inside seem to shift only when he's not looking directly at them.

CLO
These shapes... feel familiar.

Xel'thi drifts past him, her antennae tracing the air.

XEL'THI
Vaults repurpose memory. Be careful what you recognize.

Clo kneels. Lifts a CRACKED SIGIL PLATE, shaped like a six-pointed shard. The metal hums faintly, syncing to the pulse of the DRIFTHEART fragment in his chest.

Navasi sweeps the chamber with her scanner, static interference blooms and distorts the readout, scattering data like shrapnel.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
Misaligned rhythm. The Vault is dreaming crooked.

A deep RUMBLE rolls through the stone. Dust rains from above.

A section of wall exhales mist as a HIDDEN DOOR grinds open, ancient gears shrieking in protest.

NAVASI
Let's move.

CLO
Quietly, this time.

They slip into the dark beyond.

CUT TO:

INT. VAULT SYSTEM CORE - UNSEEN LOCATION - SAME

A cathedral of crystal and shadow. The air bends with raw Drift energy, unstable, uncontained.

From the center, a sudden BLOOM OF DRIFTLIGHT ignites the void. Glyphs shimmer awake across the walls, but not in sequence, they appear like fragments of a memory trying to recall itself.

Beneath them: a SEALED PODIUM deep within the Vault's heart. Inside, the SECOND DRIFTHEART SHARD stirs faintly, its crystalline surface veined with light.

The resonance jumps —

— ACROSS THE STARS —

A third shard answers. A GREEN PULSE through a jungle canopy. Broken sunlight over ancient stone. Heat and vines clinging to a forgotten tomb.

VOICE (V.O. - DRAETH)
She'll find it. The Vault will show her. Just like before.

BACK TO:

The sealed shard reacts — not to proximity, but to IDENTITY.

FLASHES —

— Navasi's hand on the first shard, five years ago.

— The Vault door splitting open.

— Draeth's silhouette in the shadows.

BACK:

One path in the glyph lattice BURNS BRIGHTER than the rest. Lines rearrange until a final symbol etches itself midair —

THE SIX-POINTED SHARD.

The light dies, plunging the chamber into silence.

The Vault waits.

A low, resonant TONE bleeds into the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. DRAETH'S FLAGSHIP - OBSERVATION DECK - DRIFTSPACE

Cold light spills through crystalline viewports, catching the edges of matte-black armor and mirrored display panels.

Draeth stands alone. Controlled. Measured. Not emotionless — but carved by purpose. One hand clutches a worn locket, flickering with a damaged holo-image of a child's laugh frozen mid-frame.

Beyond the glass, the Drift shimmers in unnatural hues, trembling not from motion, but from anticipation.

A HOLO-MAP flickers beside him. The ECHORIFT pulses as a node. A psionic shudder ripples through its center. Draeth feels it before the projection registers. His grip on the locket tightens.

DRAETH
(under breath)
Something else moved… deeper.

The map fractures, stabilizes.

The ENFORCER phases into the room behind him, gliding like oil over water, its form bending the light.

ENFORCER
The Vault breathes. The shard calls louder.

DRAETH
And the others hear it too.

ENFORCER
They move toward it.
(pause)
Let them.

DRAETH
The Driftlight pulse confirmed the second shard. They'll reach it soon.

ENFORCER
As intended. Let the Vault weigh them.

A flicker of tension sharpens Draeth's jaw.

ENFORCER (CONT'D)
Still you hope? Hope is what keeps them alive… and keeps you bound.

DRAETH
The deal was clear. She opens the Vault, my family walks free.

The Enforcer leans in, voice a psionic tremor.

ENFORCER
They breathe only because we allow it. And suffer because you stall.

A faint glow burns behind Draeth's eyes. The runes etched into his skin shimmer, a blood oath rekindled under old scar tissue.

DRAETH
Then let's end it.

ENFORCER
Release the tethered.

DRAETH
Activate all remaining Vaultborn. Scatter their path — drive them inward.

ENFORCER
And if they fail?

DRAETH
They won't. She'll reach the chamber. The Vault will open.

The Enforcer tilts its head, eyes flashing mirrored Drift glyphs.

ENFORCER
Then pray the Apex does not reach her first.

Draeth freezes. A shadow of recognition in his eyes. He turns toward the wall of surveillance feeds.

One flickers — a corridor wrapped in shadow. A shape moves just outside the light, too large to be human.

DRAETH
It's already moving.

The Enforcer raises a claw toward the map. The Drift around the Echorift now pulses — slow, rhythmic.

Like a heartbeat.

ENFORCER
Then let the Vault finish what it began.

The locket in Draeth's hand flares faintly, in time with that pulse.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT CORRIDOR - SAME

The glyphs along the walls pulse in perfect sync, guiding Navasi and Clo deeper into the dark.

INT. ECHORIFT - GRAVITY SHEAR PASSAGE - NIGHT CYCLE

The residual hum from the Vault Antechamber still lingers, a ghost-note from the Guardian's dying resonance. Glyph motes drift like ash in the air.

A long corridor splits into tangled catwalks, its center swallowed by a pulsing GRAV-CORE that distorts space itself. Metallic debris floats in slow, chaotic spirals. Weapons fire here would bend. One wrong move and you drift.

No up. No down. Only the pull.

Navasi, Clo, and Xel'thi creep along a half-melted service strut, boots magnetized.

CLO
This place makes me feel like my guts are upside down.

XEL'THI
They probably are.
(off his glance)
You'll adapt. Or pass out. Whichever's more entertaining.

A warning blip from Navasi's scanner.

NAVASI
Movement. Left flank. Too fast for static drift.

Xel'thi's antennae flex.

XEL'THI
Vault-sigs. Pattern, hostile. Four… no, six.

Suddenly —

BLAST FIRE.

Vault-born DRAETH MERC DRONES ambush from three angles, leaping from rafters and vault plating. Scavenged armor. Jagged Drift-tech wiring. Fast. Ruthless.

Their targeting locks on Clo, too precise to be random.

XEL'THI (CONT'D)
It knows him.

Clo drops into zero-G, mag-boots releasing. He spins into open space, arms flailing.

CLO
Whoa whoa whoa—!

Navasi fires, the bolt curves in the grav-shear, severing a drone's leg. She dives off the strut, grabs a drifting pipe mid-air, spins, lands behind another drone —

BLAST. SPIN. KICK.

NAVASI
Stay in the motion, Clo! Don't fight the drift — use it!

Clo steadies, using the pulse staff like a rudder, letting the pull sling him past a drone. He SLAMS the staff into its stabilizer node.

SPARK. EXPLOSION. The drone spirals into a hull wall and detonates.

CLO
That counted, right?

NAVASI
Half a kill. Don't get cocky.

Xel'thi flips along the ceiling, GRAVITY TWISTING around her. She tosses burst mines with surgical precision.

XEL'THI
Let's dance, little programs.

The mines detonate in slow-motion shockwaves, sending two drones crashing into a shattered viewport. One is sucked into vacuum — the other latches to the frame and fires inside.

A bolt strikes Clo's arm. He yells, spinning again.

NAVASI
Clo!

She boosts off the wall, catching him mid-spin, SLAMMING a drone with her heel as she flies. Gunfire. Strobe light. Drifting shrapnel.

Clo tumbles, dazed. Navasi clips her harness to him.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Hang on, Stray.

She fires the tether launcher —

— it WHIPS them toward a central control node.

Mid-air, she holsters her pistol, draws her resonator knife, and slashes a power relay —

BOOM. An EMP pulse ripples through the grav-core, distorting the field for a split second.

The last drone glitches, limbs jerking, before shattering against the catwalk. Silence.

Metallic debris floats like fractured bone through the still corridor.

Xel'thi drifts down, cloak folding like wings. Lands feline-smooth.

XEL'THI
Needlessly theatrical.

NAVASI
You're welcome.

CLO
Can we agree no more fights without floors?

Navasi braces him, clips a stabilizer to his harness.

NAVASI
You kept pace. That matters.

She scans ahead — a ruined panel, a sealed bulkhead beyond. The scorch pattern matches the six-pointed shard.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Not a patrol. They were here to bleed us.

She touches the panel. It flickers, syncing faintly to Clo's chest fragment.

XEL'THI
Pulse resonance matches the glyphs above. This door isn't meant to be opened alone.

A low TREMOR ripples through the deck. Growing.

CLO
What was that?

XEL'THI
Something deeper… waking.

The panel BLEEDS LIGHT, aligning in perfect sync with Clo's heartbeat.

NAVASI
(to herself)
And someone's pushing it open from both sides.

She taps the last sequence. With a GRINDING GROAN, the bulkhead IRISES open.

Driftlight spills in cascading pulses. Cold, stale air howls past them. The Vault's hum rises, resonant enough to carry across the Drift.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. DRAETH'S FLAGSHIP - OBSERVATION DECK - SAME

The same pulse reverberates through his holo-map.

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT HEART CHAMBER - NIGHT CYCLE

The corridor tightens, then opens with a soundless GROAN.

A cathedral of fused alloy and psionic threadwork. The VAULT HEART — crystalline, suspended by gravitational tethers. Glyphs orbit like fading stars. The Vault breathes.

Above, the DRIFT-KEY MATRIX spins like a fractured halo, unstable.

XEL'THI
(low)
This is where it begins… or ends.

NAVASI
What am I looking at?

XEL'THI
The glyph core. Finish the sequence… or the Vault folds into recursion collapse.

CLO
And if we're wrong?

XEL'THI
Then we wake everything still dreaming below.

Navasi's scanner shorts. She turns to Clo.

NAVASI
You recognize anything?

Clo steps forward. Glyphs ignite faintly, reflected in his eyes.

FLASH MEMORY:

— Cryopod lights flicker.

— Rows of clone children.

— Glyphs searing into his chest.

CLO
They weren’t building maps. They were building minds. Codifying thought.
(beat)
This isn’t a map. It’s a memory.

He raises his hand. His chest glyph glows. Fingers trace ancient motions. The Matrix shudders.

XEL’THI
(softly)
He remembers.

A RESONANCE PULSE spirals inward. The VAULT HEART responds.

NAVASI
What are you?

CLO
I don’t know.
(beat)
But I think I was meant to be here.

XEL’THI
This wasn’t built by Drift engineers.

NAVASI
Then who?

XEL’THI
Rogue Starfinders. Starborn cults. Shirren scholars who tried to trap chaos with symphony.

CLO
And failed.

XEL’THI
Or vanished. The corps rewrote the ruins.

NAVASI
AbadarCorp.

XEL’THI
They branded it. Not built it.

A harmonic ripple stirs. Clo steps forward.

NAVASI
Clo, wait—

CLO
I can read it.

His hand hovers. Glyphs sync to breath.

FLASH MEMORY:

— Starships wired to child minds.

— Glyph engines burning out.

— Voices crying in Driftlight: “Don’t forget us.”

CLO (CONT’D)
They used kids. Dreamers. Navigators.

XEL’THI
Glyphs couldn’t survive recursion. So they cloned. Anchored Vaults to minds.

NAVASI
And the glyphs fed on them.

XEL’THI
Until the system broke under its own minds.

CLO
So I’m not a mistake.

XEL’THI
No. You’re the last attempt.

NAVASI
And Draeth wants to hijack it.

XEL’THI
To reshape the Drift. Rewrite the lanes. Rebuild the universe without gods.

CLO
Not power. Authorship.

XEL’THI
Through minds that never had a choice.

A low panel PEELS BACK — revealing a FORGOTTEN RECESS.

INT. ECHORIFT - FORGOTTEN ANTECHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

Inside, a CLONE CHILD, age 8, unconscious in a dormant glyph pod. The pod glyphs sync to Clo's fragment.

Clo freezes. His breath catches.

CLO
He's… like I was.

NAVASI
(reeling)
They kept trying.

XEL'THI
One of the last. The matrix was failing.

Clo kneels, gently lifts the boy. His hands tremble — not from strain, but recognition.

CLO
When Navasi found me… I didn't know what I was either. Just a broken shape that dreamed of stars.
(beat)
She gave me a name.

Navasi watches him cradle the boy, the same fierce grip she once gave him.

CLO (CONT'D)
I won't let them break him.

He carries the child into the corridor.

NAVASI (V.O.)
I pulled Clo out of a Corp lab the day he was to be incinerated.
(beat)
Didn't know what he was. Didn't care.
(beat)
He was just… alone. Like I'd been.

Clo walks a step behind, the boy on his shoulder.

NAVASI (V.O.)
Guess he found his own stray now.

INT. ECHORIFT - LOWER CORRIDOR PASSAGE - CONTINUOUS

The passage darkens. The Vault resists. Glyphs sputter.

XEL'THI
This Vault wasn't abandoned.

NAVASI
Then what was it?

XEL'THI
Quarantined.

NAVASI
I've seen Vault tech blacklisted. Even by AbadarCorp. Whole crews gone. No trace.

XEL'THI
That wasn't failure. That was Corpse Fleet harvest. Testing what wakes.

CLO
From what?

XEL'THI
A Drift construct. A navigator who drifted too far… and brought the echo back with him. It fragmented.

CLO
And now it hunts?

XEL'THI
Now it feeds.

A low GROWL vibrates in the walls, the metal subtly warping toward them.

NAVASI
So what's Draeth playing at?

XEL'THI
He thinks he can master it. That the glyph system will obey.

The corridor shudders. In the Vault Heart the Matrix spins faster, as if listening.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT HEART CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The crystalline VAULT HEART pulses erratically, each throb answering the shard in Navasi's grip. Glyphlight coils up her arm, threading into her breath. Her skin prickles, veins faintly luminescent.

A low HARMONIC RUMBLE swells, not just here, but elsewhere.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. DRAETH'S SHADOWVAULT CHAMBER - SAME

A flickering glyph monitor registers the same harmonic. The DRIFTHEART pulse spikes. Clo's neural driftprint flares — identical to scans from years ago.

DRAETH
You don't even know what you are…
and still the Vault sings for you.
(into comms)
Prepare the strike. She's opened
the path.

THE ENFORCER (V.O.)
And the recursion predator?

DRAETH
It must feed before it slumbers
again. If it catches them before
the Vault opens, it eats
everything.

MATCH BACK TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - FINAL ACCESS CORRIDOR - NIGHT CYCLE

Walls constrict. Static thickens. Light bends. Navasi's breath hitches — shardlight webbing across her collarbone.

NAVASI
We're close.

XEL'THI
Closer than anyone's ever come.

The unconscious clone child in Clo's arms glows faintly, glyphs answering his fragment. Clo studies the walls —

CLO
They're stuttering.

Navasi lays her shard-gloved palm to the surface. The glove flares —

— SILENT SHOCKWAVE —

The wall PEELS OPEN, revealing a hidden alcove. Floating within: the DRIFTHEART SHARD, silver-veined, crystalline, humming directly to her.

She reaches —

FLASH MEMORY:

— FRACTAL STELLAR MAP burns away.

— A CHILD'S HAND slipping from hers — DRAETH'S face through smoke.

— THREE FIGURES in white void — BRIGH, CASANDALEE, EPOCH — singing the Vault glyphs.

— HER OWN FACE, flickering between past and present.

— A HINT of something vast, many-limbed, moving through the Drift.

BACK TO SCENE:

Navasi sways. Clo steadies her.

CLO (CONT'D)
Navasi. Stay with me.

XEL'THI
Not the shard… her memory. She carries what the Vault lost.

The shard dims, then drifts into her palm. A DEEP GROAN rolls through the Vault —

— far below, a LOCK disengages.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - DEEP STRIKE PLATFORM - SIMULTANEOUS

Draeth stands amid soldiers prepping grav-charges. His eyes fixed on the echo-feed — Navasi's vitals, Clo's driftprint, Vault state.

DRAETH
They'll never understand what it takes to wake a dead galaxy.
(MORE)

DRAETH (CONT'D)
(beat)
Retrieve the two Driftheartsh. If she resists… end her.

MATCH BACK TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - FINAL ACCESS CORRIDOR - NIGHT CYCLE

Navasi exhales. Two DRIFTHEARTS now glow, one in her palm and the second through her jacket.

NAVASI
Two shards in hand. But the last one's not here.

XEL'THI
No. This Vault never held it, only the memory of where it fled.

CLO
So we're not here to take it. We're here to find it.

They move toward a glyph-lit stairwell, energy sharp, focused.

XEL'THI
The mnemonic archive. Final lock. Final echo.

NAVASI
Then we find that map… and finish this.

They descend —

— and below, the Vault's pulse syncs with the shard's hum.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT CORE CHAMBER - NIGHT CYCLE

Cold. Dim. The ancient heart stirs with fractured light. Stone conduits pulse with uneven Drift energy.

A CRYSTALLINE CRADLE looms at center, wrapped in psionic alloy. Burnt glyphs and bone-char inlays mark old sacrifices.

Draeth approaches, stripped of command posture, something older in his stride.

CONSOLE FLICKER:

GLYPH ALIGNMENT - COMPLETE

MEMORY TAP ACTIVE

WARNING - ENTITY PRESENCE UNCONTAINED

SECURITY OVERRIDE FAILED - RED SIGMA

Deep claw marks rake the wall. A torn CORPSE FLEET insignia dangles.

DRAETH
You wanted to sleep forever. But forever never asked the galaxy's permission.

He drives a corrupted bio-catalyst injector into the interface —

A SHOCKWAVE bursts. Glyphlight flares. The CRADLE trembles. Air hums with buried memory.

IN THE SYSTEM:

— Cryo-chambers spark awake.

— Subsystems spiral.

— Drones glitch — a BLUR of CLAWS tears across a final feed.

CONTINGENCY BREACH CONFIRMED

NYSSHOLORA-CLASS ENTITY DETECTED

BACK TO CHAMBER:

The floor splits. A COLUMN rises, revealing a BLACK METAL SHARD — the final MAP FRAGMENT — locked in psionic suspension.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Control the door… control the stars.

He touches the shard —

THE MAP SURGES — resisting. The Vault whispers his name.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
It's time.

The VAULT HEART beats faster. Glyphs reverse. Something ancient responds.

Draeth withdraws, calm.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Let them come. They'll open the last lock for me.

He vanishes into steam, the Vault ALIVE behind him.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - DEEP SHAFTS - SAME

Dark. Then —

A SILHOUETTE slithers. Too many limbs. Too many eyes. A guttural ROAR vibrates the walls. The sound bleeds upward into the corridors above.

The NYSSHOLORA is hunting.

Its limbs scrape Drift-conductive walls, leaving trails of corroded glyphfire.

CUT TO:

INT. ECHORIFT - FINAL ACCESS CHAMBER - MOMENTS LATER

Navasi, Clo, Xel'thi, and the boy reach a vaulted doorway. Glyphfire pulses in reverse. The VAULT HEART begins to fold inward.

XEL'THI
The map shard will lead us off-world, but not if this place seals.

NAVASI
Then we break the rhythm.

The Vault trembles. Doorway IRISES OPEN. Blue light spills out. A single TONE calls.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Draeth's inside.

XEL'THI
And something else.

A low, alien reverberation rolls through the chamber, the same we heard in the shafts.

NAVASI
He's using us to finish what he couldn't.

CLO
Then we finish it our way.

Behind them, the Vault reshapes.

Remembering.

INT. ECHORIFT - VAULT CORE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS

The stairwell descent spills them into a cathedral of low-frequency harmony. The air shivers with every breath. Columns HUM, bending light through drifting motes of psionic dust. Glyphs flicker — not in pattern, but in emotion.

At the center, a DARK PEDESTAL, untouched by light, as if the Vault itself averts its gaze. Hovering above it — a BLACK METAL FRAGMENT, drinking in every glow.

XEL'THI
The Vault is remembering.

NAVASI
It's grieving.

Clo steps forward. The unconscious clone child in his arms stirs, eyes fluttering open.

CHILD
(whisper)
…you run into it.

Clo freezes, the words hitting like a buried shard of memory.

CLO
A line she used to say.

The ambient glyphs spiral toward the pedestal. It OPENS. The fragment hovers higher, a cipher of black metal, veins of silver fire.

XEL'THI
Not a Driftheart. A cipher.

NAVASI
The map.

Clo reaches. His fingers brush it — THE VAULT SURGES —

FLASH VISIONS:

— A storm-choked jungle world.

— A drifting derelict.

— A stellar graveyard.

— DRAETH'S SILHOUETTE, waiting.

CLO (SHAKEN)
Three places. One remains.
(beat)
"Seek the Fold Beyond Time."

The shard fuses to his chest, pulsing with the Vault's heartbeat.

NAVASI
We move. Now—

The Vault's pulse distorts. Light warps. Temperature plummets.

A BLACK GATE TEARS OPEN.

The ENFORCER steps through, obsidian eyes, Driftsteel veins, shadows coiling like living smoke.

ENFORCER
You took what was Draeth's to claim.

He raises a corrupted hand. Shadows POUR outward, leeching the warmth from bone.

NAVASI
Back up.

ENFORCER
Draeth won't end you. But I will.

Shadow tendrils lash —

— CLO shields the child, twisting mid-air.

— XEL'THI slams into a wall, glyphlight bleeding from her skin.

— NAVASI cracks her head against a pillar, dazed.

ENFORCER (CONT'D)
The truth was never yours to hold.

A strange HUM slices through the chaos.

DRAETH (O.S.)
And you were never meant to wield it.

FLASH — Draeth behind him, SOULBLADE igniting in a single psionic flare — DRIVING through the Enforcer's chest.

The Enforcer SCREAMS as the blade UNLEASHES A DEATHWAVE — shadows flayed to static, his form collapsing. The blast hurls Draeth back, glyphlight rupturing across his body.

NAVASI
Draeth—

He twitches, doesn't rise.

The VAULT GROANS. A SHRIEK erupts from below —

The NYSSHOLORA ascends like a collapsing cathedral — limbs of broken geometry, too many eyes, glyphfire dripping from its breath. The Vault's grief given form.

XEL'THI
A Vault-born shame. They tried to erase it. But it remembered.

Draeth forces himself upright. Barely.

NAVASI
Take the shards. The map. Get out.

She pulls TWO DRIFTHEART SHARDS from her vest, slamming them into Clo's palm.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
Find the Fold. Finish what we started.

CLO
Not without you.

NAVASI
That's an order, Stray.

The child — eyes locked on Navasi — echoes softly.

CHILD
Finish what we started.

A beat. Clo nods, a single rolls down his cheek. Xel'thi grips his arm.

XEL'THI
Live, Xel. That's how you serve me now.

VEERA (V.O.)
Emergency channel active. Clo — I've found your exit.

They vanish in a ripple of smoke.

Navasi turns — bloodied, calm.

The beast slithers closer, its roar a physical force.

DRAETH (WEAK)
Not a beast. A mistake.

He stands beside her, blade humming.

DRAETH (CONT'D)
Do you remember what I said the first time we ran?

NAVASI
You said… "Save yourself."
(beat)
But I never did.

FLASH MEMORY:

— Younger Navasi and Draeth. Holding hands. Watching a drifting starfield.

NAVASI (CONT'D)
I loved you once. But I can't forgive you.

DRAETH
Then don't. Just fight.

They charge.

SLOW MOTION:

— Navasi FIRES.

— Draeth LEAPS.

— The Soulblade DRIVES into the beast's core.

BACK:

NAVASI (V.O.)
She told me — you don't run from injustice. You run straight into it.

Navasi SLAMS the detonation key — the scar on her wrist igniting with the Vault's first-awakening light.

DRAETH
Why?

NAVASI
Because some sins… are unrepeatable.

The TATTOO of WEYDAN ignites on her arm as time magic tears her apart at the edges.

DRAETH
And once… I knew who I was.

They lock eyes.

Not forgiveness. Not hate.

Just truth.

A kiss of light —

THE VAULT DETONATES.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. DEEP SPACE - THE ROUGH DRAFT - ESCAPE

The ROUGH DRAFT blasts from the burning wreckage of the ECHORIFT station, a nova of shattered light. The Vault detonation blooms behind it, a shockwave swallowing an ABADAR CORP CRUISER in a molten flare. Metal screams as the cruiser tears apart.

Beyond the debris cloud, the silhouette of a MASSIVE CORPSE FLEET DREADNOUGHT looms, unmoving. Watching.

The Rough Draft vanishes into the Drift — the detonation light still chasing its wake.

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - COCKPIT - MOMENTS LATER

CLO and XEL'THI sit in silence. The RUNE-KEY fragment rests on the dash, glowing faintly with the same pulse that once beat in the Vault's heart. Smoke-streaked stars drift past the viewport.

The YOUNG CLONE CHILD sleeps, curled beneath a blanket, his chest glyph faintly echoing Clo's.

CLO
(quietly)
I always felt like a kid around her. Truth is… I was more like a parent. Watching her take it all on. Letting her.

XEL'THI
Worthiness isn't given. It's chosen. And you — Stray — were chosen long before you knew.

CLO
I'm not magic. I'm not even whole.

XEL'THI
The magic of this universe isn't spells or relics. It's will. Wonder. Believing you can make something from nothing.

Clo swallows. Nods.

CLO
She believed in me when no one else did.

XEL'THI
Then believe in yourself now.

The DRIFTHEART SHARD in its cradle pulses once — a deep, resonant tone. The STARMAP pings — a single coordinate flaring like a heartbeat.

CLO
Where the stars still remember.

The child stirs.

CHILD
(softly)
Kat…

Clo smiles, gentle.

CLO
Yeah. Kat.

He grips the yoke. The Rough Draft JUMPS — the stars pulling into streaks.

INT. ROUGH DRAFT - PERSONAL QUARTERS - LATER

Clo sits on a bench. In his hand: the RUNE-KEY fragment. Beside him, NAVASI'S COMPASS.

He opens it. Inside: her initials. The needle never pointed.

CLO (V.O.)
"Direction is a myth. You walk the trail you believe in."

He closes it.

CLO
I'm still walking, Navasi. For both of us.

He stands, taller now, not the same Stray who followed.

INT. SEONI'S SHIP - MAIN CHAMBER

Aetherlight ripples through suspended glyph-globes. SEONI meditates before a living DRIFT MAP. One sector flares — the coordinates where ECHORIFT once stood.

Her eyes open.

SEONI
The one we watched… may not be the one we expected.

A CLOAKED FIGURE from the prologue stands in the shadows — still, listening.

Seoni rises, taking up a blade — half-sorcery, half-metal — and a Pathfinder talisman worn thin by time.

SEONI (CONT'D)
Time to gather the others.

The Rune-Key symbol flares in the map's heart.

EXT. DRIFT VOID - UNKNOWN

A STASIS POD drifts among fractured stars, spinning slowly in the dark.

INT. STASIS POD - CONTINUOUS

NAVASI. Pale. Still. A faint blue Driftlight glow burns behind her closed eyes. Her fingers twitch.

A whisper — her own voice from the Vault — echoes faintly.

NAVASI (V.O.)
Some sins are unrepeatable.

Her eyes SNAP OPEN.

CLOAKED FIGURE (V.O.)
The one has awakened.

EXT. UNKNOWN WORLD - JUNGLE PLANET - TWILIGHT

Vines part, revealing ANCIENT BLACK STONE, a VAULT ENTRANCE carved into cliffs like the bones of a dead god.

DEEP WITHIN, a THIRD DRIFTHEART SHARD pulses in the dark. Not dormant.

Waiting.

Reacting.

The pulse matches Navasi’s newly opened eyes.

TITLE CARD:

PATHFINDER x STARFINDER

THE STORY CONTINUES